The Borrowed Breath

Conspiration, Pneumatocracy, and the Inheritance of Fate in the Cinema of Ari Aster



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Abstract

This dissertation advances a unified theory of the cinema of Ari Aster — the short films of 2011–2016 and the features *Hereditary* (2018), *Midsommar* (2019), *Beau Is Afraid* (2023), and *Eddington* (2025) — as a sustained and cumulative **pneumatology of heteronomy**. Against the dominant frames through which the work has been received (trauma allegory, the "elevated" or "post-horror" debate, the folk-horror revival, and the psychoanalytics of the monstrous-feminine), it argues that the corpus is organized by a single, insistently literalized figure: breath held in common and on loan. In every film the subject's respiration — its *pneuma*, *ruach*, *spiritus*, *anima* — is disclosed as an endowment issued by an anterior collective and repayable on demand. Etymology supplies the governing name. A conspiracy (*con-spirare*) is, in the strict sense, a breathing-together; Aster's covens, communes, mothers, and networks are conspiracies in exactly this sense, and the films' notorious "happy endings" are scenes of **synchronous apotheosis**, in which individual respiration is at last absorbed into a collective breath.

The dissertation names this regime **pneumatocracy** — sovereignty exercised through the administration of breath — and traces its migration across the oeuvre: from the demonic (the Goetic king Paimon), to the ethnic-communal (the Hårga), to the maternal-corporate (Mona Wassermann's conglomerate), to the viral-algorithmic (the pandemic town and data center of *Eddington*). Each migration enlarges the diorama that is Aster's master form — house, village, psyche-as-world, network-as-nation — and each relocates the archaic theology of inherited liability (Exodus 20:5), which prophetic and Kantian modernity believed it had revoked (Ezekiel 18; the autonomy of the will), into a new secular apparatus. The argument is assembled from Greek tragedy (the *Oresteia*, the *Trachiniae*, the *Bacchae*); Walter Benjamin's definition of fate as the guilt-context of the living; the comparative mythography of Frazer, Graves, and Adam of

Bremen; the psychoanalytic theory of birth-anxiety (Rank, Freud), transgenerational haunting (Abraham and Torok), and intromission (Laplanche); Irigaray's critique of the forgetting of air; Canetti's typology of crowds; Esposito's dialectic of *communitas* and *immunitas*; and the atmospheric politics of Sloterdijk and Mbembe. Aster is read against a comparative field running from Euripides and Kafka's "The Judgment" through Hawthorne, Lovecraft, *Rosemary's Baby*, *The Exorcist*, *The Wicker Man*, and *The Witch*, from which two new genre figures are derived: the **Crowned Girl**, successor to Clover's Final Girl, and her structural counterpart, the **Hollow King**.

The study further argues that Aster's formal signature — the miniature, the symmetrical tableau, the God's-eye overhead, the protracted take, and a *Hereditary* score composed by a virtuoso of circular breathing — constitutes a respiratory form that regulates the spectator's own breath (**apneic spectatorship**), rendering the cinema itself the last conspiracy. It closes by extracting from this negative pneumatology a positive ethics: an ethics of the **caesura** (Hölderlin), informed by Levinas's account of the psyche as inspiration by the other, in which breath may be shared without being surrendered.

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Prefatory Note on Corpus, Method, and Conventions

Corpus. The primary corpus comprises the short films Aster completed between 2011 and 2016 — *The Strange Thing About the Johnsons* (2011), his AFI Conservatory thesis film; *Beau* (2011); *Munchausen* (2013); *Basically* (2014); *The Turtle's Head* (2014); and *C'est la vie* (2016) — and the four features distributed by A24: *Hereditary* (2018), *Midsommar* (2019; theatrical and extended cuts), *Beau Is Afraid* (2023), and *Eddington* (2025). Productions of Square Peg, the company Aster founded with Lars Knudsen (among them Kristoffer Borgli's *Dream Scenario*, 2023, and *The Drama*, 2026), form a paratextual penumbra and are not analyzed. At the time of writing, Aster's fifth feature, *Scapegoat*, is in preparation at A24 with Scarlett Johansson attached, Jacob Elordi joining, and Jude Law in negotiations; its plot remains undisclosed (Deadline, 23 September 2026; Variety, 6 May 2026). The film lies outside the corpus, but its title — the name of the sacrificial figure this dissertation identifies as the structural constant of the oeuvre — is addressed in the Conclusion.

Method. The dissertation proceeds by what it calls *constellational philology*. Following the "Epistemo-Critical Prologue" of Benjamin's *Origin of the German Trauerspiel* (1928), in which ideas stand to phenomena as constellations stand to stars, it does not deduce a doctrine from the films; it arranges their recurrent particulars — a click of the tongue, a hose taped to an exhaust pipe, a pill that must be swallowed with water, a mask refused at a grocery checkout — until a figure becomes legible. Three registers are interleaved: close formal analysis (mise-en-scène, duration, sound); etymological hermeneutics, on the premise that the semantic field of breath (*spirit*, *inspire*, *expire*, *conspire*, *aspire*; *pneuma*, *psychē*, *anima*, *ātman*/*Atem*) is itself a sedimented theory of the soul; and comparative

genealogy across tragedy, scripture, mythography, psychoanalysis, and political philosophy.

Lineage and resonance. Two orders of claim are distinguished throughout. *Attested lineages* are those Aster has acknowledged or that the films cite on their surface: Greek tragedy in *Hereditary*'s classroom, the Goetic king Paimon, *The Wicker Man* and *The Wizard of Oz* behind *Midsommar*, the Jewish-maternal comedy and odyssey structure of *Beau Is Afraid*, the Western behind *Eddington*. *Constellational resonances* — De Quincey's Levana, Kafka's "The Judgment," the etymology of *influenza*, the astronomer whose surname *Eddington* shares — are offered as interpretive structures, not as hypotheses about intention. The study accepts Wimsatt and Beardsley's caution against the intentional fallacy (1946) while declining its austerity: a corpus this saturated with designed signs invites, and finally thematizes, the hunt for hidden design. Chapter 11 turns that hunt back upon itself.

Conventions. Films are cited by title and year; plot particulars are given only as the argument requires them. Classical, biblical, and Norse texts are cited by standard divisions; modern texts by author and date of first publication. Interview statements are treated as paratexts in Genette's sense (*Seuils*, 1987) — thresholds of interpretation, indicative rather than authoritative.

Introduction

The Children's Teeth Are Set on Edge

The proverb is quoted in order to be abolished. "The fathers have eaten sour grapes, and the children's teeth are set on edge," say the exiles, and the prophet replies that the saying shall no longer be used in Israel: the soul that sins shall die, and the son shall not bear the iniquity of the father (Ezekiel 18:2–4, 20; cf. Jeremiah 31:29–30). Ezekiel's revocation of the Decalogue's visitation clause — iniquity visited upon the children unto the third and fourth generation (Exodus 20:5; 34:7) — is among the founding gestures of the moral individual. The ledger closes at the boundary of a single life. Kant secularizes the gesture when he makes the *autonomy* of the will the supreme principle of morality and names every determination of the will by something outside it *heteronomy* (*Groundwork of the Metaphysics of Morals*, 1785, §II). Liberal personhood, juridical responsibility, and the therapeutic culture that inherited both rest on the Ezekielian settlement. Aster's cinema reopens the case.

In *Hereditary* a grandmother's covenant consumes her daughter and grandchildren. In *Midsommar* a woman whose family has been annihilated by her sister's illness is absorbed into a community that redistributes grief as common property. In *Beau Is Afraid* a son's every act is pre-audited by a mother who is also a corporation. In *Eddington* a pandemic town's private grievances, inherited paranoias, and borrowed slogans are metabolized by

a network that no one governs. In each case the children's teeth are on edge; what changes is the agent of visitation — no longer God but, successively, a demon, a commune, a mother, and a machine. The films do not depict heteronomy as a moral failure to be overcome. They propose it as the subject's constitutive condition. What the Ezekielian settlement treated as a wall — the skin of the individual life — Aster treats as a membrane, and the membrane he films most insistently is the airway.

The critical field

Four frames dominate the reception of the corpus, and each is right about something it cannot explain. The first is **trauma allegory**, licensed by Aster's own paratexts: *Hereditary* described as a family tragedy that curdles into nightmare, *Midsommar* as a breakup film dressed as folk horror. The frame is accurate about content and silent about form. It translates the supernatural into the psychological, a translation the films refuse: Paimon is not a metaphor for grief; grief is the medium through which Paimon operates. The second is the debate over **"elevated horror" or "post-horror"** (Rose 2017; Church 2021), which situates Aster in an A24-branded art-horror cycle beside Eggers, Peele, Kent, and Mitchell. Useful as a sociology of taste, it mistakes slow tempo and compositional restraint for an evasion of genre, when they are an intensification of genre's oldest operations: curse, ritual, possession, sacrifice. The third is **folk-horror revivalism**, whose most serviceable instrument, Scovell's "folk horror chain" of landscape, isolation, skewed belief, and summoning (2017), illuminates *Midsommar* and little else. The fourth is **psychoanalytic feminism** (Kristeva 1982; Creed 1993), which correctly locates the archaic mother at the corpus's gravitational center but tends to stop at the abject, where Aster begins. His mothers are not abject. They are sovereign.

What the four frames share is a reluctance to take the films at their literal word. This dissertation does so, and the literal word is breath.

The hypothesis

Charlie Graham's airway closes in anaphylaxis, and she dies leaning from a car window for air. Terri Ardor pipes exhaust into her parents' bedroom and into her own mouth. The elders of the Hårga groan as they die, and the community groans with them. Christian is rendered mute by a powder blown into his face. Beau Wassermann enters the world without crying and leaves it by drowning. The sheriff of Eddington is an asthmatic who will not wear a mask during a respiratory pandemic that coincides with a protest movement whose watchword is "I can't breathe." This is not one motif among others. It is the corpus's material substrate.

The choice of substrate is philosophically exact. Breath is the one vital function that is at once autonomic and voluntary: governed by the respiratory centers of the brainstem, yet suspendable, quickenable, and shapeable by the will. It is therefore the precise somatic site of the question that autonomy and heteronomy pose — the place in the body where self-government and other-government visibly meet. It is also, across the languages from which Western psychology took its vocabulary, the first name of the soul: Greek *psychē*, from *psychein*, to blow; *pneuma*; Latin *anima*, cognate with Greek *anemos*, wind, and *spiritus*, from *spirare*; Hebrew *ruach* and *neshamah*; Sanskrit *ātman*, cognate with German *Atem*. To ask who breathes for the subject is to ask, in the oldest vocabulary available, who owns the soul.

Hence the governing term, **conspiration**, recovered from the Latin *conspirare*, to breathe together. Aster's films are conspiracy films in this strict sense. The coven that surrounds the Graham family, the Hårga that surround their American guests, the surveillance apparatus that surrounds Beau, and the networked paranoias that surround a New Mexico town are collectives that breathe in common and breathe *for* the subject. The dissertation's central claim — the **Conspiration Thesis** — has five parts. First, the subject's breath is borrowed: there was never a first breath that was one's own (the *pneumatic loan*). Second, the lender is a collective whose bond is respiratory (*conspiration*). Third, sovereignty in Aster is the administration of breath — its granting, withdrawal, synchronization, and suspension (*pneumatocracy*). Fourth, the sovereign Breather migrates historically, from demon to commune to mother-corporation to algorithm, and each migration enlarges the diorama in which the subject is enclosed. Fifth, the films' endings, which

audiences experience as perverse consolations, are scenes of *synchronous apotheosis*: the moment at which an individual's respiration finally coincides with the collective's, and the self dissolves into the air it was always borrowing.

The thesis also has a historical edge. Charles Taylor describes secular modernity as the replacement of a "porous" self, open to spirits and forces, by a "buffered" self sealed against them (*A Secular Age*, 2007). Aster's corpus documents the failure of the buffer. Its subjects prove porous after all, and the pore is the airway. What enters through it is not the premodern spirit-world returning intact but that world's functions reassigned, one by one, to the institutions modernity built to replace it: the family, the community, the corporation, the network.

Plan of the dissertation

Part I reconstructs the genealogies on which the corpus draws. Chapter 1 reads Aster's fatalism through Greek tragedy, Benjamin's theory of fate and of the *Trauerspiel*, and the biblical antinomy of visitation and individual accountability. Chapter 2 assembles the occult and ethnographic archive: the *Ars Goetia*, the Norse sources behind the Hårga, Frazer, Graves, Bachofen, and the sociology of sacrifice. Chapter 3 constructs a psychoanalytic genealogy of the borrowed breath, from Rank's birth trauma to Irigaray's forgetting of air. Part II offers readings: the short films (Chapter 4), then a chapter on each feature, organized by a respiratory figure — *Hereditary* as inspiration, *Midsommar* as conspiration, *Beau Is Afraid* as *angustiae*, *Eddington* as influenza (Chapters 5–8). Part III widens and synthesizes: Aster among horror and mythological fiction (Chapter 9); the formal pneumatics of diorama, duration, and sound (Chapter 10); and the Conspiration Thesis stated as ten propositions, with a reflexive reckoning with the paranoid reading the films invite (Chapter 11). The Conclusion extracts from Aster's negative pneumatology an ethics of the caesura.

Part I

Genealogies

1 Fate as Guilt-Context: Tragedy, *Trauerspiel*, and the Visitation Clause

2 The Occult and Ethnographic Archive

3 Psychoanalytic Genealogies of the Borrowed Breath

Chapter 1

Fate as Guilt-Context: Tragedy, *Trauerspiel*, and the Visitation Clause

1

Aster's fatalism is not a mood but a jurisprudence. This chapter reconstructs its three sources — Attic tragedy, the biblical theology of visitation, and Walter Benjamin's theory of fate — and shows that the corpus preserves the juridical form of each while removing its theological guarantor.

1.1 The classroom as oracle

In *Hereditary* the curriculum is the prophecy. Peter's English class discusses Sophocles' *Women of Trachis*, and a student proposes that the tragedy is greater, not less, if its figures are pawns in a hopeless machine. The choice of play is exact. In the *Trachiniae*, Deianira, fearing displacement by the captive Iole, sends Heracles a robe smeared with the blood of the centaur Nessus, which the dying centaur had told her was a love-charm. The philtre is poison; the robe consumes Heracles' flesh; he orders his own pyre on Oeta. In agony he recognizes an oracle of Zeus fulfilled: he was to die by no living hand but by one already dead (*Trach.* 1159–63). The dead kill the living — *Hereditary*'s plot in a sentence, its antagonist a deceased grandmother whose design survives her.

The play's second structure belongs to the next film. A woman prepares a love-charm to bind a man; the charm becomes the instrument of his burning. That is the arc of Christian in *Midsommar*, bound by Maja's philtres and consigned to the fire. *Hereditary*'s classroom thus contains,

proleptically, the program of its successor. The syllabus is a prophecy of the oeuvre.

1.2 Tragedy without *hamartia*

Aristotle defines the finest tragedy by reversal (*peripeteia*), recognition (*anagnorisis*), and the error (*hamartia*) of a person neither wicked nor faultless (*Poetics* 1452a–1453a). *Hereditary* deletes the *hamartia*. The catastrophe proceeds through contingencies — a party, a cake made with nuts, a deer carcass on a dark road — whose contingency is designed: the pole that kills Charlie bears the coven's sigil. The Grahams err constantly (Annie's rages, Peter's negligence, Steve's quietism), yet no error is causally sufficient; the catastrophe would have found another road. Recognition is redistributed from the characters to the spectator, who reads the sigil before anyone in the film does. Aster's tragedy is one of spectatorial recognition and characterological opacity. We know the oracle; they live it.

1.3 Benjamin: fate as the guilt-context of the living

Benjamin's "Fate and Character" (written 1919, published 1921) supplies the grammar. Fate, he argues, belongs not to religion but to law. It is the guilt-context of the living (*Schuldzusammenhang des Lebendigen*), the order in which misfortune is read as the sign of a guilt that precedes any act, and in which mere life stands condemned in principle. The fortune-teller can read fate from signs because fate has already made life a legible text of culpability. Character, by contrast, belongs to comedy: the comic figure's traits shine as freedom rather than guilt.

Two consequences follow for Aster. First, his fate is juridical. The cults are courts: the Hårga's elders adjudicate, Beau is literally tried, Eddington's sheriff enforces a law he is dissolving. Second, the comedy that audiences detect in these films, often uneasily, is the residue of character inside fate. Steve's exhausted decency, Mark's crudeness, Beau's helpless politeness, and Joe Cross's self-pity are funny because they are the last free traits of persons already sentenced.

Benjamin's "Critique of Violence" (1921) completes the picture. *Mythic* violence, exemplified by Niobe's punishment, founds law, sheds blood, and leaves guilt behind; *divine* violence, exemplified by the earth swallowing

Korah's company, destroys law, is bloodless, and expiates. Aster's collectives practice mythic violence without remainder: the Hårga's festival re-founds the community's law in blood; Paimon's coronation founds a dynasty. Divine violence never arrives. No power intervenes to annihilate the law itself. That absence is the theological signature of the corpus.

1.4 *Hereditary* as *Trauerspiel*

In *The Origin of the German Trauerspiel* (1928), Benjamin separates Attic tragedy — the hero's silent, sacrificial break with mythic fate, which founds a new community — from the baroque mourning-play, whose stuff is history as natural history, creaturely suffering, sovereign indecision, and allegory. The allegorist petrifies life into emblem; history appears under the *facies hippocratica*, the death's head. *Hereditary* is a *Trauer-spiel* in the literal sense: a play of mourning. Annie Graham is its allegorist. Her miniatures convert each catastrophe — the hospice, her mother nursing the infant Charlie, the interior of the car — into an emblem fixed under glass, and the film's preeminent emblem is the one Benjamin names: the corpse, here Ellen's headless body in the attic. The film's genre is not horror inflected by tragedy but *Trauerspiel* disguised as horror.

1.5 The House of Atreus, run backward

The *Oresteia* is Western drama's founding narrative of inherited guilt: the Thyestean feast, Agamemnon's sacrifice of Iphigenia, Clytemnestra's revenge, Orestes' matricide, the Erinyes' pursuit, and the trial at the Areopagus. In the *Eumenides*, Apollo argues that the mother is not the parent of the child but only the nurse of the seed newly sown (*Eum.* 657–66); Athena, born of a father without a mother, casts the vote that acquits Orestes; the Furies are rehoused beneath the city as Kindly Ones. Bachofen read the trilogy as the overthrow of mother-right by father-right (*Das Mutterrecht*, 1861), and Irigaray as the record of a founding matricide (1981).

Aster runs the *Oresteia* backward. In *Hereditary* the Furies are the founders: a matriarchal coven whose law precedes and outlasts the fathers, who burn, starve, or hang. In *Beau Is Afraid* the *Eumenides* is reversed outright. A son who has assaulted his mother is tried in an

amphitheater; the mother prosecutes; his defender is thrown from a ledge; he is drowned. Apollo's seed-father — the father reduced to insemination — appears in literal form, as the phallic creature in the attic (Chapter 7).

1.6 The *Bacchae* under a nightless sun

In Euripides' *Bacchae* (405 BCE), Dionysus returns to Thebes as a disguised stranger. Pentheus, the rationalist king, wants to see the maenads' rites; disguised, he spies, is discovered, and is torn apart by the women, led by his mother Agave, who carries his head home believing it a lion's. *Midsommar* is architected on this play: an emissary from the god's country (Pelle), scopic men destroyed for looking (Josh photographing the forbidden book; Christian, the anthropologist-voyeur), a flayed man, a man sewn into an animal, a chorus of women.

Nietzsche's *Birth of Tragedy* (1872) names what the Bacchic rite does: Dionysian intoxication shatters the *principium individuationis*, Schopenhauer's principle of individuation, and returns the individual with rapture to primordial unity. Apollo is the god of light, form, and the boundaries of the self. *Midsommar*'s paradox is to stage Dionysian dissolution under Apollonian light — the self dissolved in the glare of individuation's own god.

1.7 Visitation, wager, binding

The Hebrew Bible holds the antinomy the corpus re-litigates. Against the visitation clause stand Deuteronomy's limit on vicarious punishment (24:16) and Ezekiel's revocation. Between them stands Job: a wager in heaven, a righteous man tested, friends who insist that suffering signifies guilt (Benjamin's fate exactly), and a God who answers from the whirlwind — from moving air. *Beau Is Afraid* restages the wager with a mother in the place of God: Mona stages her own death to test her son's love. The Akedah (Genesis 22), read by Kierkegaard as the teleological suspension of the ethical (*Fear and Trembling*, 1843), is inverted throughout the corpus: the parent tests the child, and no angel stays the knife. Annie's admission that she kept Peter from her mother but surrendered the infant Charlie to her is a Molech transaction (Leviticus 18:21; 2 Kings 23:10): one child passed through the fire to purchase the other.

1.8 *Unetaneh Tokef*: fate as inscription

The High Holy Days poem *Unetaneh Tokef* declares that on Rosh Hashanah it is written and on Yom Kippur it is sealed who shall live and who shall die: who by fire and who by water, who by sword and who by beast, who by plague, who by strangling. As an inventory it is uncanny. Steve and Christian die by fire, Beau by water; Charlie's airway strangles her; Christian is sealed inside a beast; Eddington lives under plague. More decisive than the inventory is the theology of inscription. Fate is written before it is lived and sealed before it is suffered. This dissertation calls that operation the **pre-scription**, and it is the corpus's master gesture: the Breather writes before it breathes.

The poem, however, ends with a remedy: repentance, prayer, and righteousness avert the severity of the decree. Aster's universe keeps the decree and deletes the remedy.

1.9 Synthesis

Tragedy without *hamartia*, *Trauerspiel* without redemption, theodicy without God, liturgy without remedy: the juridical form of fate survives intact — court, decree, inscription, sentence — while its guarantor is replaced. Who, or what, occupies the vacated seat is the question the remaining chapters answer.

Chapter 2

The Occult and Ethnographic Archive

Aster's supernatural is bookish. Its demons have bibliographies and its pagans have footnotes. This chapter reconstructs the archive — Solomonic magic, Norse sources, Victorian comparative mythography, and the sociology of sacrifice — and argues that each source enters the films already bent toward a single operation: the capture of the subject's breath by a collective that writes before it breathes.

2.1 The Goetic sovereign

Paimon is not Aster's invention. He is the ninth spirit of the *Ars Goetia*, the first book of the seventeenth-century compilation known as the *Lemegeton* or *Lesser Key of Solomon*, and he appears earlier in Johann Weyer's *Pseudomonarchia Daemonum* (1577), the catalogue of demons appended to Weyer's skeptical treatise on witchcraft. The 1904 edition of the *Goetia* prepared by S. L. MacGregor Mathers and published by Aleister Crowley fixed the description modern occultism inherited: a great king obedient to Lucifer, crowned, riding a dromedary, preceded by a host of spirits with trumpets and cymbals; a being of enormous voice who roars at his first coming; a teacher of all arts, sciences, and secret things; a giver of dignities who binds men to the will of the operator.

Three features of this portrait govern *Hereditary*. The crown becomes the film's final emblem, set upon the severed head of Charlie Graham. The

promise of knowledge and preferment becomes the coven's contract, summarized in Ellen's annotated books. The roaring arrival of a sovereign announced by music and breath becomes the film's acoustic logic, which culminates in an acclamation. Giorgio Agamben has argued that acclamation — the shout of the assembled — is the liturgical form through which sovereignty is constituted rather than merely recognized (*The Kingdom and the Glory*, 2007). The naked congregation's "Hail Paimon" is glory in Agamben's sense: sovereignty produced by collective exhalation.

The deeper borrowing is procedural. Goetic evocation is a technology of containment. The operator stands within a protective circle; the spirit is called into a triangle drawn outside it; the boundary between the two is the whole of the operator's safety. *Hereditary* abolishes the triangle. The spirit is not evoked into a figure outside the body but incarnated into a lineage, and the family becomes the vessel the triangle once was. Ceremonial magic held the demon at a distance; hereditary magic installs him in the heir.

2.2 The written house

The Graham house is a written surface. Its walls carry occult formulae — *Satony*, *Zazas*, and *liftoach pandemonium*, the last combining the Hebrew infinitive "to open" with Milton's coinage for the capital of hell (*Paradise Lost* I.756). The coven communicates through books, annotations, photographs, and a sigil that recurs on a pendant, in the pages of a grimoire, and on a telephone pole. Before anything is breathed in *Hereditary*, something is written. The house is a palimpsest of the pre-scription introduced in Chapter 1, and the film's first image — an obituary card — is its first page.

2.3 The Norse palimpsest

The Hårga is a fiction compounded from documented sources, and its logic lies in the compounding rather than in ethnographic fidelity. Four strata are legible.

- **Uppsala.** Adam of Bremen's *Gesta Hammaburgensis ecclesiae pontificum* (c. 1075, IV.26–27) describes a festival at the temple of Uppsala held every nine years, at which nine males of every living kind, humans included, were sacrificed and hung in the sacred grove.

Midsommar's festival recurs every ninety years and demands nine victims: Adam's ennead, multiplied.

- **The windy tree.** In the *Hávamál* (138–41), Odin hangs nine nights on a wind-rocked tree, wounded by a spear, given as a sacrifice of himself to himself, and takes up the runes. Script is acquired by self-sacrifice on a tree in the wind. The Hårga's runic inscriptions, its ever-growing scripture, and its ancestral tree, fed with the ashes of the dead, reassemble the scene.
- **The family cliff.** *Gautreks saga* describes the *Ættarstapi*, the "family cliff" from which the old threw themselves to spare their kin, the legendary basis of the Ättestupa; modern scholarship doubts its historicity, which is precisely its value to a film about invented tradition.
- **The dance of Hårga.** A legend of Hälsingland tells of young people at Hårga lured by a stranger's fiddle — the Devil's — into a dance they could not stop, up the mountain, until only bones remained. *Midsommar*'s maypole contest, danced until all but one collapse, is that legend made into a selection mechanism.

Two further Norse resources illuminate the corpus beyond *Midsommar*. Bear ceremonialism, documented across the circumpolar world (Hallowell 1926), and the warrior figure of the *berserkr*, commonly glossed "bear-shirt," stand behind Christian's final costume. And the *Ynglinga saga* records that Odin preserved the severed head of Mímir with herbs and charms, so that it spoke secret knowledge to him (cf. *Völuspá* 46). The oracular head — Mímir's, Orpheus's still singing after his dismemberment, Brán's in the Welsh *Branwen* — is the mythic prototype of *Hereditary*'s crowned head.

2.4 Frazer's external soul and the year-king

James George Frazer's *The Golden Bough* (third edition, 1906–15) is the master text behind modern folk horror, and two of its doctrines govern Aster. The first is the sacred king: the King of the Wood at Nemi, who holds office until slain by his successor, and the agrarian rituals in which a king, or his substitute, is killed to renew the fertility his body embodies. Robert Graves systematized the figure into the year-king consort of the Goddess, sacrificed at midsummer and displaced by his tanist (*The White Goddess*, 1948). Christian is a Gravesian year-king: elected by the May Queen, mated to a priestess for the increase of the community, and burned.

The second doctrine is less often noticed and more important. In *Balder the Beautiful* (1913), which also gathers the midsummer fire-festivals of Europe and Caesar's report of the Gauls' wicker colossi filled with living men (*De Bello Gallico* VI.16), Frazer expounds the **external soul**: the folk belief that a life may be stored outside the body — in an egg, a box, a tree planted at birth — so that whatever befalls the object befalls the person. Frazer calls such an object a *life-index*. *Hereditary*'s sketchbook is one: when Annie throws it into the fire, the flames take a body. *Midsommar*'s ancestral tree is another, a collective life-index, which is why urinating on it is a capital offense. The external soul is the folkloric form of the borrowed breath: a life kept in an object held by others.

Behind Frazer and Graves stand J. J. Bachofen's *Das Mutterrecht* (1861), which posited a matriarchal stage of civilization prior to paternal law, and Erich Neumann's Jungian *The Great Mother* (1955), with its Terrible Mother who devours what she bears. As history these works are discredited; Ronald Hutton's *The Triumph of the Moon* (1999) has documented how the fantasy of an unbroken pagan religion was manufactured from such sources. As myth they remain potent, and Aster uses them as myth: as modernity's dream of a premodern order in which the community, and the mother, hold the breath of all.

2.5 Theories of sacrifice

Every major theory of sacrifice is legible in the Hårga's festival; the films' originality lies in what they add.

Henri Hubert and Marcel Mauss defined sacrifice as the establishment of communication between sacred and profane through a victim destroyed in the course of the ceremony, distinguishing the *sacrifier* who benefits from the *sacrificer* who officiates (1899). Émile Durkheim located the sacred in the collective effervescence of assembled bodies: the group, aroused, worships its own force (*The Elementary Forms of Religious Life*, 1912). René Girard derived sacrifice from mimetic crisis, resolved when the violence of all converges upon one — *unanimity minus one* — whose death restores peace and is retroactively sacralized (*Violence and the Sacred*, 1972; *The Scapegoat*, 1982). Georges Bataille described human beings as discontinuous creatures who die alone, and sacrifice and eroticism as violations through which continuity is glimpsed (*Erotism*, 1957; *The Accursed Share*, 1949). Mauss, in *The Gift* (1925), showed that gifts compel return; in the short essay "Gift-Gift" (1924) he noted that the Germanic *Gift* names both a present and a poison. Victor Turner's liminality and *communitas* (*The Ritual Process*, 1969) and Mircea Eliade's eternal return (1949) complete the inventory: the Hårga's seventy-two-year life, divided into four eighteen-year seasons, is sacred time in Eliade's sense, a cycle in which death is scheduled rather than suffered.

What Aster adds is the medium of the bond. In the Hårga the victim's dying is shared by sound and breath: the community groans with the elder who survives his fall and screams with the volunteers who burn. Durkheim's effervescence and Girard's unanimity are rendered as respiration in common. Mauss's poisoned gift is literal — the drinks, the pie, the tea — and Bataille's continuity is achieved, at the film's close, as a single collective exhalation.

2.6 The anthropologist as Pentheus

Midsommar is also a satire of ethnography. Josh has come to write a dissertation on midsummer festivals; Christian, who has no topic, takes his; both treat the Hårga as material. Malinowski's posthumous diary (*A Diary in the Strict Sense of the Term*, 1967) exposed the resentments beneath the founding ethnographer's sympathy; Clifford Geertz's "thick description" (1973) and James Clifford and George Marcus's *Writing Culture* (1986) recast ethnography as a literary practice whose authority is manufactured on the page. The Hårga understand this better than their guests. They perform for observers, permit some records and forbid others, and keep a counter-text, the *Rubi Radr*, that writes the observers into its story. Josh dies for photographing it; Christian is burned with his unwritten thesis. The anthropologists come to transcribe the community and are transcribed by it. In the corpus's terms, they mistake themselves for authors in a world where the pre-scription is held by others.

Chapter 3

Psychoanalytic Genealogies of the Borrowed Breath

Psychoanalysis has always known that the first breath is borrowed; it has rarely said so in those words. This chapter assembles, from Freud to Irigaray, the theory of a subject whose respiration begins as a debt to the maternal body and whose anxiety is the memory of that debt coming due.

3.1 *Angustiae*: anxiety as remembered strangulation

In the twenty-fifth of the *Introductory Lectures* (1917), Freud proposes that the affect of anxiety repeats the first great danger of life, the act of birth, with its separation from the mother and its respiratory distress. He notes that the German *Angst* carries the sense of narrowness, *Enge*, as Latin *angustiae* names the straits; the constriction of breathing that was a real consequence of birth is reproduced in every later attack of anxiety. Otto Rank generalized the point into a system: all anxiety derives from the trauma of birth, and all culture is an effort to undo the expulsion from the womb (*Das Trauma der Geburt*, 1924). Freud's reply in *Inhibitions, Symptoms and Anxiety* (1926) demoted birth from cause to prototype and recast anxiety as a signal of danger, the danger being the loss of the object.

The etymology is more radical than either theorist. English *anxiety* descends from Latin *anxius* and the verb *angere*, to choke or squeeze; its cognates are *angor*, strangling, and *angina*, the closing of the throat. Anxiety is, in its oldest meaning, a remembered strangulation. A film titled *Beau Is Afraid* that opens inside the birth canal, and whose hero is told

that sexual climax will stop his heart, is a treatise on *angustiae* in this precise sense (Chapter 7).

3.2 The uncanny home and the hijacked mourning

Freud's "The Uncanny" (1919) defines the *unheimlich* as the familiar returned in estranged form and makes an observation the corpus takes literally: the female genitals, often uncanny to neurotic men, are the entrance to the former *Heim* of every human being. Aster's horror is never the strange intruding on the home. It is the home disclosed as the strangest place of all: the Graham house, the Hårga "family," the maternal mansion to which Beau returns, the town that Eddington's sheriff wants to protect.

In "Mourning and Melancholia" (1917), mourning is the slow withdrawal of attachment from a lost object; melancholia refuses the loss by taking the object into the ego, so that, in Freud's phrase, the shadow of the object falls upon the ego. Each Aster film begins with a loss whose mourning is captured by a collective: a grief group fronting for a coven, a commune that offers to grieve on Dani's behalf, a mother who stages her own death to audit her son's grief, a pandemic whose dead are displaced into conspiracy. The cult in Aster is a parasite of mourning. It offers the bereaved what mourning cannot: a total meaning, and someone to breathe for them.

3.3 The phantom and the crypt

Nicolas Abraham and Maria Torok distinguished *introjection*, the gradual assimilation of a loss, from *incorporation*, the fantasy of swallowing the lost object whole and sealing it in an intrapsychic *crypt* (*The Shell and the Kernel*, 1978). In "Notes on the Phantom" (1975), Abraham extended the theory across generations: the *phantom* is a formation in the unconscious of a child produced by a secret in the unconscious of a parent. What haunts, in his account, is not the dead but the gaps others' secrets leave in us.

Hereditary is the most rigorous cinematic exposition of the phantom yet made. Ellen's secret, never spoken by Annie and perhaps never fully known to her, governs three generations: it acts in Annie's sleepwalking, draws in Charlie's sketchbook, clicks in Charlie's mouth, and finally

possesses Peter outright. When Annie, at her own séance, speaks in her dead daughter's voice, the phantom achieves what Abraham says it seeks — ventriloquism of the unspeakable.

3.4 Intromission and the confusion of tongues

Jean Laplanche's general theory of seduction holds that the adult's messages to the infant are enigmatic, compromised by the adult's own unconscious, and that the infant becomes a subject by translating them (*New Foundations for Psychoanalysis*, 1987). Normally the message is *implanted* and worked over; under violent conditions it is *intromitted*, forced in so that it cannot be translated, only harbored ("Implantation, Intromission," 1990). Annie's account of her brother's suicide note — that their mother had been trying to put people inside him — is a clinical vignette of intromission, and Paimon is intromission personified: a message that can be hosted but never metabolized.

Sándor Ferenczi's "Confusion of Tongues between Adults and the Child" (1933) described how the abused child, confronting the adult's language of passion with its own language of tenderness, introjects the adult's guilt and identifies with the aggressor. The corpus explores both halves of the formula. *The Strange Thing About the Johnsons* and *Munchausen* render the poisoned tenderness of the family. *Midsommar* converts the confusion of tongues into its liturgical opposite, a gift of tongues, when Dani suddenly understands Swedish in the dance (Chapter 6).

3.5 Holding and impingement

Melanie Klein's paranoid-schizoid position splits the object into good and bad to protect the infant from its own ambivalence ("Notes on Some Schizoid Mechanisms," 1946); Mona Wassermann, provider and persecutor, is that split object made executive. D. W. Winnicott's "holding environment" names the maternal provision that allows the infant's "going-on-being," and *impingement* the environmental intrusion that interrupts it (1960). Pelle asks Dani whether Christian makes her feel held and whether he feels like home: Winnicott's question, posed by a recruiter. The Hårga offer a perfected holding environment, which is to say a total impingement — holding without release. Beau's life, conversely, is impingement without holding: notices under the door, a stranger in the bathtub, a therapist on his mother's payroll.

3.6 Foreclosure and the crocodile

For Jacques Lacan, the Name-of-the-Father is the signifier that substitutes for the enigma of the mother's desire and anchors the child in the symbolic order; its *foreclosure* produces psychosis (*Seminar III*, 1955–56). The paradigmatic case is Daniel Paul Schreber, whose *Memoirs of My Nervous Illness* (1903), analyzed by Freud (1911), describe divine rays entering his body, his transformation into a woman to be impregnated by God, and a "soul murder" committed against him. Morton Schatzman's *Soul Murder: Persecution in the Family* (1973) read the delusions as encrypted memories of the orthopedic child-rearing devised by Schreber's father. A family's methods became a son's cosmology.

Hereditary's male line is a gallery of foreclosure: Annie's father starved by psychotic depression, her brother hanged in their mother's room, her husband a mild nullity, her son vacated. Paimon is the delusional supplement: a demonic Name-of-the-Father manufactured by a matriarchal coven to install sovereignty where the paternal function has failed. In *Seminar XVII* (1969–70), Lacan likens the mother's desire to the open jaws of a great crocodile, held apart only by a stone roller, which he calls the phallus. *Beau Is Afraid* stages the image with startling literalism: the paternal phallus exists, but it is imprisoned in the attic, and when it fails, the jaws close over the son.

3.7 The first atmosphere

Julia Kristeva's *Powers of Horror* (1980) defines the abject as what the subject must expel to become separate, preeminently the archaic maternal body; Barbara Creed's *The Monstrous-Feminine* (1993) catalogued the horror film's archaic mothers, monstrous wombs, witches, and possessed girls. Luce Irigaray supplies the element both omit. In *The Forgetting of Air in Martin Heidegger* (1983), she charges Western metaphysics with forgetting air, the element that gives itself without being owned, and connects that forgetting to the forgetting of the mother: in the womb the child breathes through the mother's blood; birth is the first breath taken on one's own. In "Body against Body: In Relation to the Mother" (1981), she argues that Western culture rests not on Freud's primal parricide but on an older matricide, legible in the *Oresteia*.

Irigaray's two theses meet in Aster. The mother is the first atmosphere; the first breath is a separation from her and therefore a debt to her. Aster's mothers refuse to let the debt lapse. They remain the atmosphere.

3.8 The familial factory

Gilles Deleuze and Félix Guattari's *Anti-Oedipus* (1972) charged psychoanalysis with reducing desire to the triangle of "daddy-mommy-me" and described the family as a colony of capitalist social production, the place where social desire is privatized and resold as personal guilt. *Beau Is Afraid* stages their argument with a literalism they might have admired. The mother is a conglomerate whose logo marks the products of Beau's world; the analyst is her employee; the Oedipus complex is a product line.

3.9 Synthesis: the pneumatic loan

Assembled, these theories yield a single structure. The subject's first breath is given by separation from a body that breathed for it, and so is owed (Irigaray). Anxiety is the remembered constriction of that first breath (Freud, Rank). The parent's unmetabolized message enters the child as a foreign body (Laplanche) or as a phantom (Abraham and Torok); where the paternal function fails, a delusional sovereign is installed (Lacan, Schreber); and the family is the factory in which this debt is produced and collected (Deleuze and Guattari). The dissertation calls the structure the **pneumatic loan**. Aster's films are its collection notices.

Part II

Readings

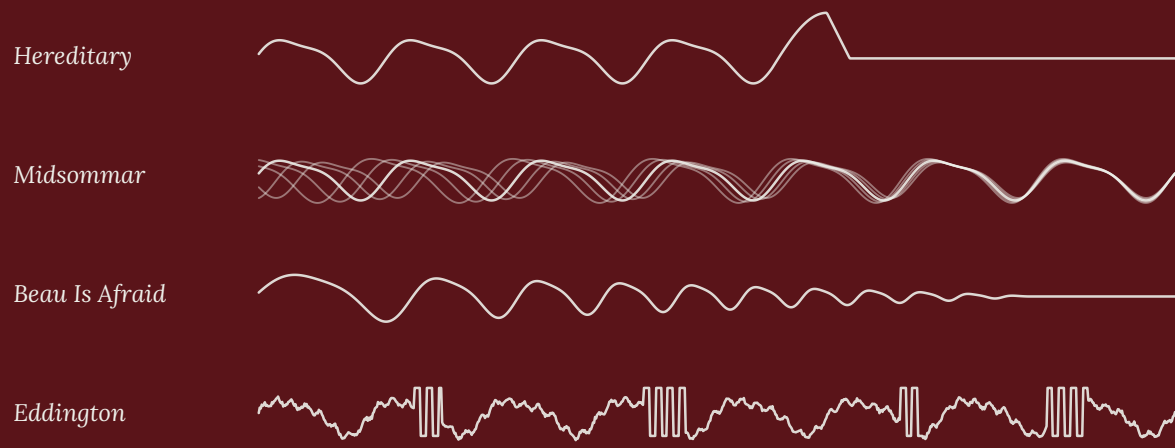
4 Prolegomena in Miniature: The Short Films

5 *Hereditary*: Inspiration and the Inheritance of the Last Breath

6 *Midsommar*: Conspiration, the Lamenting Pack, and the Inverted Pentecost

7 *Beau Is Afraid*: *Angustiae*, Birth, and the Crocodile Mother

8 *Eddington*: Influenza, Viral Sovereignty, and the Algorithmic Breather



Chapter 4

Prolegomena in Miniature: The Short Films

4

The short films are Aster's laboratory. Each isolates, at small scale and under controlled conditions, an element the features later compound: the family as a closed circuit of guilt, the poisoned gift of maternal love, the obstructed homecoming, the phallus as comic remainder, and the monologue as a failed claim to self-authorship.

4.1 *The Strange Thing About the Johnsons* (2011)

Aster's AFI thesis film, which premiered at Slamdance and later circulated virally online, inverts the most familiar narrative of domestic abuse: a son's prolonged sexual abuse of his father. The inversion is not provocation for its own sake. By reversing the generational vector, the film exposes the structure that remains when the content is turned upside down: a household organized around a secret, in which guilt circulates rather than terminates and every member is conscripted into its keeping. The decisive event is an act of inscription. The father's attempt to commit the secret to writing breaches the household's conspiracy of silence and precipitates catastrophe. Already the corpus's law is in force: the family is a closed text, and to write against its pre-scription is to die. The film's sentimental decorum — swelling score, composed domestic interiors — laid over unspeakable content inaugurates the tonal estrangement that will define the features, a comedy of decorum in which form refuses to register what it contains.

4.2 *Beau* (2011)

A man preparing to fly to his mother steps back inside his apartment for a moment and returns to find his keys gone from the door. Unable to leave the apartment unlocked, he cannot leave at all. This six-minute seed contains the founding obstruction of *Beau Is Afraid*: a son prevented from reaching his mother, and guilty for being prevented. Anxiety appears here as spatial *angustiae*: the world narrows to a doorway the son cannot cross in either direction. What is borrowed is not yet breath but passage, and the mother's call on the telephone is the creditor's voice.

4.3 *Munchausen* (2013)

Wordless, scored in the idiom of the sentimental animated-feature montage, *Munchausen* follows a mother who cannot bear her son's departure for college and begins to poison him so that he will need her; he dies. The title names the syndrome Roy Meadow christened in 1977, Munchausen syndrome by proxy, in which a caregiver fabricates or induces illness in a dependent. The film is the corpus's purest statement of the maternal *pharmakon*: love administered as poison, by mouth, to prevent separation. It anticipates Mona Wassermann's medicalized surveillance and the Hårga's drugged hospitality, and it sets a formal precedent. The absence of dialogue leaves the score to speak, and the film's emotional instruction to the audience proceeds in direct contradiction to its content. The spectator is made to feel tenderness while watching a murder, a first experiment in governing the audience's breath from outside.

4.4 *The Turtle's Head* (2014)

A womanizing private detective discovers that his penis is shrinking. Genre parody and castration comedy, the film treats the phallus as a vanishing, ridiculous object whose diminution exposes the dependence of masculine self-display on an organ the subject does not control. Its significance for the corpus is anticipatory. The phallus appears here as a comic remainder; in *Beau Is Afraid* it returns as a monstrous one, imprisoned in the attic. Between the two lies the corpus's consistent treatment of male sovereignty as hollow: a crown, an office, or an organ that works through the man rather than for him.

4.5 The monologue films: *Basically* (2014) and *C'est la vie* (2016)

These films are built from monologue: a single speaker narrates a life directly to the camera, with a composure the life does not warrant. They are formally the most "autonomous" works in the corpus, the only ones in which a subject appears to author its own account without visible interference. Their irony is that the self-narrating voice is the least reliable instrument available. The speakers' sentences have been written for them by class, milieu, and catastrophe; the monologue is a pre-scription recited in the first person. The features will never again grant a protagonist this much control of the soundtrack, and when Beau, in the forest, watches his imagined life performed as theater, he is the spectator of a monologue spoken in his name by others.

4.6 What the laboratory established

By 2016 the elements were in place. The family is a closed circuit of guilt (*Johnsons*); love is a poison given by mouth (*Munchausen*); the way home is blocked, and the blockage is the son's fault (*Beau*); the phallus is a remainder rather than a power (*The Turtle's Head*); and the first-person voice is a script (*Basically*, *C'est la vie*). What the shorts lack is scale: a collective large enough to breathe for the subject, and a duration long enough to make the spectator breathe with it. The features supply both.

Chapter 5

Hereditary: Inspiration and the Inheritance of the Last Breath

Hereditary (2018) is a film about what enters a body through its mouth. Its demon is installed by breath, its victims die at the airway, its matriarch transmits herself orally, and its climax is an acclamation. The film's figure is **inspiration** in both senses: the drawing-in of air and the possession of a vessel by a spirit not its own.

5.1 Writing first, then the diorama

The film begins with text: an obituary card for Ellen Taper Leigh. The dead woman's name precedes every living image. Then the camera crosses Annie Graham's studio and pushes into a miniature of her son's bedroom, which, without a cut, becomes the real room where Steve wakes Peter. Two founding operations are performed before a word is spoken. The first is the pre-scription: the dead are written before the living move. The second is the **diorama**: the living are figures in an enclosure built and observed from outside.

The miniature is not a metaphor for determinism; it is the apparatus of determinism. The camera adopts the eye of whoever built the house, and the final image, which renders the treehouse coronation with the stillness of a tableau under glass, retroactively assigns the whole film to that eye. We have been watching from the position of the coven, or of Paimon, or of an author whose formal control is the visible form of their design. The film's theodicy is architectural.

5.2 Annie the allegorist

Annie's miniatures reproduce her life's catastrophes as they happen: the hospice, the interior of the car after Charlie's death, and, most revealingly, her mother attempting to nurse the infant Charlie. Dominick LaCapra distinguishes *acting out*, the compulsive repetition of trauma, from *working through*, its articulation and partial mastery (*Writing History, Writing Trauma*, 2001). Annie's art presents itself as working through — it is a gallery commission, a profession, a discipline — but functions as acting out at reduced scale. It does not metabolize the trauma; it fixes it as emblem, which is the work of Benjamin's allegorist (Chapter 1).

The nursing miniature deserves particular weight. It records the grandmother's claim on the granddaughter as an oral transmission, breast to mouth. Inheritance in *Hereditary* passes through the orifice that both feeds and breathes. Annie has made a model of the moment her daughter was taken, without being able to read it.

5.3 The click: a voice without lungs

Charlie's signature is a tongue-click, and the choice is phonetically precise. Clicks are produced not by air from the lungs but by a velaric ingressive airstream — a pocket of air rarefied between tongue and palate and released with a snap. They are, in the strict sense, non-pulmonic: speech sounds that require no breath. Charlie's click is the voice of a body whose lungs are not its own, and it becomes Paimon's index. It sounds in the dark after her death, from the corner of a room, and finally in Peter's mouth. The demon announces itself with the one human sound that can be made without breathing.

5.4 The window: inspiration as execution

Charlie dies of an airway. At a party she eats cake containing nuts; her throat begins to close in anaphylaxis; Peter drives her toward the hospital; she leans from the window gasping for air; he swerves around a deer carcass; a telephone pole marked with the coven's sigil takes her head. The gesture of breathing becomes the instrument of death. *Hereditary*'s pivotal event is an inspiration that kills.

The sequence that follows is a study in suspended breath. Peter does not look back. The camera holds on his face as he breathes, drives home,

and lies in bed, and the film withholds the discovery until morning, when Annie's scream arrives from offscreen. The spectator has been made to hold breath with Peter for the length of a night (Chapter 10).

5.5 The heads

The coven's signature is decapitation, and its victims are the women of the line: Ellen's exhumed corpse lies headless in the attic, Charlie is beheaded at the window, and Annie, floating near the ceiling, saws through her own neck with piano wire. The head is the seat of breath, voice, and face. Its removal does not end the women's service; it converts them into relics. In the final tableau Charlie's head, crowned, sits upon a headless effigy before which the headless bodies of her mother and grandmother kneel. The oracular head of myth — Mímir's, preserved by Odin for counsel; Orpheus's, singing after his dismemberment — here becomes the regalia of a king who requires a male body and a female archive.

5.6 The séance as conspiracy

Joan, met at a grief group, teaches Annie a séance. Its historical lineage is modern and American: the "rappings" heard by the Fox sisters at Hydesville in 1848, which inaugurated Spiritualism as a practice of decoding knocks; the parlor circle of joined hands and held breath; and "pneumatography," the term Baron Ludwig von Güldenstubbé coined in 1857 for writing produced directly by spirits. The séance is the domestic technology of conspiration. Its participants breathe together in the dark so that another may speak through them. In Goetic magic, the circle protected the operator; at the Grahams' table, the circle is the conduit. When Annie speaks in Charlie's voice, the medium has become a mouthpiece for the phantom (Chapter 3), and the coven's plan advances under cover of grief.

Jeffrey Sconce has shown that modern media were imagined from the start as spirit media, channels for disembodied presence (*Haunted Media*, 2000). The séance in *Hereditary* is the film's internal image of itself: a darkened room in which an audience holds its breath while a voice not its own speaks.

5.7 The external soul and the fire

Charlie's sketchbook functions as a Frazerian life-index (Chapter 2): a life kept outside the body. When Annie first tries to burn it, the fire leaps to her arm. When she finally throws it into the hearth, expecting to die, it is Steve who ignites. The book was not hers to destroy, and the script reassigns the death. Fire recurs in the corpus as the element antagonistic to breath, the consumer of air. Annie's earlier sleepwalking, during which she woke to find herself and her children doused in paint thinner beside a lit match, rehearses the immolation that the film eventually delivers to the father. Gaston Bachelard named the fusion of love and death in fire the Empedocles complex (*The Psychoanalysis of Fire*, 1938); Aster distributes it by sex. Women are decapitated; men burn.

5.8 Annie's refusal

Annie is the one figure who resists the pre-scription, and her resistance takes the form of a refusal of maternity. In a scene suspended between dream and sleepwalking, she tells Peter that she never wanted to be his mother and that she tried to end the pregnancy. At the grief group she recounts keeping Peter from her mother and then, after Charlie's birth, allowing her mother access to the girl. It is a Molech bargain (Chapter 1): one child surrendered to purchase the other's safety. The bargain fails because the coven required a male host all along, and Annie's protection of her son was the precondition of his capture.

The film thereby converts the most stigmatized maternal affect, the wish not to have been a mother, into the only ethical act available. Annie is Deianira and Clytemnestra at once: the mother whose love is poison and the mother who would kill to end a line. She fails, and her failure is the film's tragedy in Benjamin's sense, the residue of character crushed by fate.

5.9 Inheritance as the last breath

The Romans recognized a custom in which the nearest kin caught the dying person's last breath with their lips. Cicero describes mothers of the condemned barred even from this office (*In Verrem* II.5.118); in the *Aeneid* Anna asks to gather with her mouth any last breath that still lingers over Dido (4.684–85). The heir (*heres*, root of *hereditary*) received the soul by mouth.

Hereditary literalizes the custom and inverts its direction. The inheritance is a breath, but it is not the ancestor's own. It is a foreign spirit she carried and passed on. The film's horror is that heredity, imagined by liberal modernity as a biological endowment the individual may overcome, is revealed as a respiratory debt to a collective that wants its breath back.

5.10 Coronation

Peter's final act of will is a leap from the attic window, an attempted refusal. It is captured at once. His body lies still, a light descends into it, and he rises, the click in his mouth, to climb into the treehouse, where the naked congregation kneels and acclaims him. Joan addresses the figure as Charlie, and as Paimon. The face Peter wears is vacated. He is the first of the corpus's **Hollow Kings**: a male sovereign elected as a vessel, crowned so that others may rule through him.

The acclamation is the film's synchronous apotheosis. The congregation breathes and shouts as one, and the House of Graham, which began as a set of separate lungs, has become a single respiratory apparatus serving a foreign king. The final image closes the diorama. We were inside it from the first shot.

Chapter 6

Midsommar: Conspiration, the Lamenting Pack, and the Inverted Pentecost

Midsommar (2019) is the corpus's most seductive pneumatocracy because its Breather does not steal. It gives. The Hårga take Dani's breath by offering to breathe with her, and the film's horror is that the offer is sincere. Its figure is **conspiration** in the strictest sense: a community whose bond is shared respiration, in grief, in sex, in death, and in fire.

6.1 Prologue as atmoterrorism

The film opens with a murder committed through air. Dani's sister Terri runs hoses from a car's exhaust into the family home, one into her parents' bedroom and one taped into her own mouth. Peter Sloterdijk dates the twentieth century from 22 April 1915 at Ypres, when chlorine gas was released not against enemy bodies but against their environment; he calls the resulting paradigm *atmoterrorism*, the conversion of the air a target breathes into the weapon against it (*Terror from the Air*, 2002). *Midsommar*'s prologue is domestic atmoterrorism: a family killed through the air it shares. Its first death is a conspiracy in the literal sense, a household made to breathe the same poison. Its last scene answers it with a community breathing the same grief.

6.2 The unheld

Between the two scenes, Dani's breathing is the index of her abandonment. She hyperventilates in a bathroom and on an airplane; she howls in Christian's arms in a long take that refuses to cut away from the sound. Christian holds her physically and absents himself in every other way. His circle is a *Gesellschaft* in Ferdinand Tönnies's sense (1887): an association of contract, irony, and calculated interest, epitomized by Christian's appropriation of Josh's dissertation topic. Pelle, who tells Dani that his own parents died in a fire and that the Hårga raised him, asks whether Christian makes her feel held and whether he feels like home. It is Winnicott's question about the holding environment (Chapter 3), posed by a recruiter. The Hårga are a *Gemeinschaft*: a community of blood, place, and shared feeling. The film's wager is that *Gemeinschaft*, fully realized, is indistinguishable from capture.

6.3 Arrival under a nightless sun

On the road north the camera turns the image upside down: the world inverted on entry. The guests take psilocybin in a field, and Dani sees grass grow through her hand. Then comes the defining formal decision: horror without night. The Hårga live in near-perpetual light, and the film's atrocities occur in the glare. This is Nietzsche's paradox, noted in Chapter 1, made into mise-en-scène. Dionysian dissolution proceeds under the god of individuation's light, and nothing is hidden because nothing needs to be. The cult does not conspire in shadow. It conspires in the open, and its openness is its argument.

6.4 The lamenting pack

The Ättestupa is the film's first public rite. Two elders, having completed their seventy-two years, leap from a cliff. The woman dies on impact; the man survives, shattered, and groans. The assembled Hårga groan with him, in pitch and rhythm, until he is finished with a mallet.

Elias Canetti's *Crowds and Power* (1960) supplies the category. Among the four primordial packs — hunting, war, increase, and lament — the *lamenting pack* forms around a member being torn away by death. It presses upon the dying, accompanies the dying in sound and gesture, and cannot let go until it has expelled the dead. The Hårga's festival comprises

all four of Canetti's packs: lament at the cliff and later around Dani; increase in the mating rite; hunting in the pursuit of outsiders; war in the sacrifice. What unifies them is the medium the film gives them: shared breath. The pack groans together, pants together, wails together, screams together. Canetti also identifies the root of power in the moment of survival, the satisfaction of standing alive among the dead. Remember it at the film's end.

6.5 The sacrificial ledger

The festival requires nine lives: four offered from outside (Simon, Connie, Josh, Mark), four from within (the two elders of the Ättestupa and the volunteers Ulf and Ingemar), and a ninth chosen by the May Queen. Adam of Bremen's Uppsala ennead stands behind the arithmetic (Chapter 2). Each death has its logic.

Josh dies for photographing the *Rubi Radr*, the forbidden scripture. He is Pentheus, killed for looking at the rites he came to record. Mark, who urinated on the ancestral tree, is flayed and his skin is worn by a member of the community, as a fool in the ritual's typology; the nearest historical analogue is the Aztec festival of Tlacaxipehualiztli, in which priests of Xipe Totec, the Flayed Lord, wore the skins of victims as a figure of spring renewal. Simon is found suspended in a coop, executed by the "blood eagle" of the Norse sagas, his ribs opened and his lungs drawn out through his back to hang like wings. Roberta Frank has argued that the rite is a later misreading of skaldic verse (1984), but its cinematic function is exact: it is the external soul of Frazer's folklore made anatomical. The organ of breath is exhibited outside the body, as a display belonging to the community.

Christian is the Gravesian year-king (Chapter 2). He is drugged, mated to a priestess for the community's increase, and then, as he flees, paralyzed by a powder blown into his face. The vector of his capture is his own inhalation. He cannot speak or scream for the remainder of the film. The victim's voice, the breath made into sound, has been confiscated. Sewn into the eviscerated body of a bear, he becomes an inverted *berserkr*: the bear-shirt confers not rage but paralysis.

6.6 The choir of increase

The mating rite is the corpus's clearest image of conspiration as an erotic technique. Maja has bound Christian with love-charms — her pubic hair baked into his food, her menstrual blood in his drink — that recall Deianira's philtre in the *Trachiniae* (Chapter 1). Christian couples with her inside a ring of naked older women who chant and breathe in synchrony with her, amplifying her cries and timing them, while one presses upon his body to assist the act.

The scene inverts a canonical image. In *Rosemary's Baby* (Levin 1967; Polanski 1968), a drugged woman is impregnated inside a ring of naked coven members. In *Midsommar* the drugged body is male and the ring is female, and its function is not concealment but amplification: the women's synchronized respiration converts a private act into a collective one. Sex is performed as a choir. The community breathes the act together, and the man is merely its instrument.

6.7 The inverted Pentecost

The maypole contest restages the Hälsingland legend of the Hårga dance, in which young people danced to the Devil's fiddle until they died. The women dance until all but one fall. During the dance, under the influence of the community's drink, Dani suddenly understands Swedish and is understood.

The Christian liturgical model is Pentecost (Acts 2:1–13): the Spirit descends upon the assembled as a rushing wind and as tongues of fire, and each hearer hears the apostles speak in his own language. Babel is undone by breath. *Midsommar* stages the event and reverses its theology. The spirit that descends is the community's own breath; its gift of tongues, Dani's xenoglossia, is the sign of her incorporation rather than her mission; and its tongues of fire arrive, completely, at the end, in the burning temple. Pentecost founded a church sent outward to the nations. The Hårga's Pentecost folds an outsider inward, permanently.

Heinrich von Kleist's "On the Marionette Theatre" (1810) explains why Dani dances best when she has ceased to direct her dancing. Grace, Kleist's interlocutor argues, belongs to the puppet, whose movement follows its center of gravity without the interference of consciousness, and to the god, whose consciousness is infinite. Humans, having eaten of

the tree of knowledge, are self-conscious and graceless; paradise is bolted behind us, and we must travel around the world to see whether it is open at the back. Dani's victory is the marionette's grace. She wins when she stops being the author of her movement, and she is crowned for it.

6.8 The oracle machine

The Hårga's scripture, the *Rubi Radr*, is continually extended by an oracle, Ruben, a child bred through deliberate incest so that his mind would be, in the community's view, unclouded. His marks are interpreted by the elders as revelation. The procedure is a hermeneutic machine for converting noise into necessity. A source chosen for its lack of intention produces signs; an institution supplies their meaning; the meaning is then enforced as fate.

Alan Turing introduced the "oracle machine" in 1939: a computing machine supplemented by a black box that answers questions the machine itself cannot decide. The Hårga's oracle is such a box. It answers the undecidable question that grief asks — why? — and the answer is always the community. The film's opening painted panels, which depict its entire plot before the first scene, perform the same operation for the spectator: they are the pre-scription, a decree published before the life it governs. Chapter 8 will meet this machine again in its computational form.

6.9 The smile

Dani finds Christian coupling with Maja and collapses into a wail. The women around her wail with her, matching her pitch and her heaving breath, and for the first time in the film her grief is not hers alone. Asked to choose the ninth victim between a randomly selected member of the community and Christian, she chooses Christian. The temple burns. Ulf and Ingemar, who had volunteered, scream as the fire reaches them; the community screams with them. Dani's face passes through horror into a smile.

Three readings compete. Aster's own paratext, which described the film as a breakup story and as a *Wizard of Oz* for perverts, frames the ending as liberation: Dorothy finds her home in Oz and declines to return to Kansas. A second reading, the most common among critics, frames it as capture: a grieving woman absorbed by a cult. The dissertation's reading

treats both as true at once. The smile is a **synchronous apotheosis**: the moment Dani's breath ceases to be hers. For the first time she is breathed with, and therefore breathed for. It is also Canetti's survivor's smile, the face of power discovering itself among the dead, and it is the smile of Lovecraft's Innsmouth narrator embracing the ancestry he feared (Chapter 9).

Hereditary's demon stole breath. The Hårga take it by giving it. That is the more dangerous pneumatocracy, and the film refuses to adjudicate between its consolation and its horror because the refusal is the point. Conspiration feels like being held.

Chapter 7

Beau Is Afraid: *Angustiae*, Birth, and the Crocodile Mother

7

Beau Is Afraid (2023) is the corpus's respiratory autobiography of a single subject, bracketed by a first breath that does not come and a last breath taken under water. Its figure is ***angustiae***: the narrow passage of birth, the constriction remembered as anxiety, and the strangulation that is the film's one autonomous act. Its Breather is a mother who is also a corporation.

7.1 A treatise on constriction

The title is a diagnosis, and the film's working title, *Disappointment Blvd.*, names its creditor's verdict. Aster's widely reported description of the project as a Jewish *Lord of the Rings* in which the hero is merely trying to reach his mother's house identifies its genre: an epic of the smallest possible distance, made infinite by guilt. As critics have observed, the film begins in a birth canal and ends in a murky, birthlike tunnel, and each of its sections opens with a movement from darkness into consciousness (The Nation). The structure is serial nativity. Beau is born again and again into worlds that accuse him, and every birth repeats the first constriction.

7.2 The first breath, and the hand that does not lift

The film opens from the infant's point of view: muffled sound, smeared light, the cord cut. The newborn does not cry. Doctors work at his airway while his mother screams at them, demanding to know why he does not cry and what is wrong with him (Film Comment). The first sound Beau hears in the open air is his mother's alarm about his breath. Rank's trauma of birth (Chapter 3) is staged without metaphor: the subject's first act is a delayed respiration, and the first voice to receive it is the creditor's.

Thomas De Quincey's "Levana and Our Ladies of Sorrow" (*Suspiria de Profundis*, 1845) recalls the Roman goddess Levana, who presided over the moment when the newborn, laid upon the earth, was lifted upright by the father's hand, or by a kinsman acting for him, in acknowledgment that it should live. The dissertation calls this the **Levana function**: the paternal act that raises the child out of the maternal element and into the world. In *Beau Is Afraid* the function is vacant. Beau's father, his mother has told him, died at the moment of conception, of a cardiac defect that makes climax fatal — a defect Beau is said to have inherited. No hand lifts him. He is received by the mother's voice, which is to say by the atmosphere she remains.

7.3 The city of pre-scription

Beau's city is a carnival of menace: a corpse lying in the street, a naked man who stabs passers-by, a tattooed stranger who chases him to his door. But its essential violence is textual. Notes slid under his door accuse him of noise he did not make. His therapist prescribes an experimental medication that must be taken with water; the building's water fails; the pill is swallowed dry and the panic begins. His keys vanish from the door, as in the 2011 short, and his flight to his mother departs without him. Each of these is a pre-scription in the dissertation's sense: an accusation, a regimen, a schedule written before Beau acts, against which every act becomes a violation. Kafka's Josef K. was arrested one morning without having done anything wrong. Beau is found guilty without having done anything at all.

Water is the element in which this guilt is administered. The pill requires it; the building withholds it; the surname means *water-man*; the

town that bears his mother's name is *Wasserton*; and the film will end in water.

7.4 The suburban Calypso

Struck by a truck, Beau wakes in the home of Grace and Roger, a suburban couple who nurse him in their dead soldier son's room, medicate him, and promise repeatedly to take him home. The episode is Calypso's island: hospitality as detention. Its pharmacology is constant — pills, painkillers, Roger's solicitude — and its inscriptions are lethal. When the couple's daughter Toni dies after drinking paint, Grace blames Beau and sends Jeeves, the traumatized veteran who lives in their yard, to destroy him. Jeeves is an Erinys: an avenging spirit dispatched by a grieving mother to pursue a son. Grace's handwritten counsel to Beau, that he should stop incriminating himself, is the film's motto. In a world of pre-scription, every act is evidence.

7.5 Demodocus in the forest

In the forest a pregnant woman named Penelope leads Beau to a traveling troupe, the Orphans of the Forest; he gives her the gift he had bought for his mother. The troupe's play becomes, through animation by Cristóbal León and Joaquín Cociña, the makers of *The Wolf House*, an alternate life in which Beau marries, fathers three sons, loses them in a flood, and searches for them. A man in the audience tells him that his father is alive.

The Homeric source is exact. In *Odyssey* VIII, among the hospitable Phaeacians, the bard Demodocus sings of Troy, and Odysseus weeps to hear his own deeds performed by another. Beau, among the forest orphans, watches his unlived life performed by others, and the life is lost to water. The episode condenses the corpus's thesis about autonomy: the only life in which Beau authors himself is a play staged by strangers, and it ends in a flood. The Penelope of this odyssey waits for no one. She is pregnant, a figure of the generativity the curse forbids him.

7.6 The terrarium

Beau reaches his mother's house in Wasserton, a towering glass structure that one critic aptly called a terrarium (The Nation). The terrarium is the diorama of *Hereditary* rebuilt at the scale of a mansion: a glass enclosure designed for observation. He has missed the funeral. Elaine, his childhood love, arrives; they make love; he survives climax, and she dies at its height. The cardiac curse — the film's literal *hereditary* condition — discharges into the woman. Mona then steps from the shadows. She is alive, she has watched everything, and the people Beau met along his route were recording him for her.

Mona Wassermann is the corpus's most complete Breather. Her conglomerate's mark appears across the products of Beau's world; her surveillance encompasses his therapy; her love is an audit. Nietzsche observed that the moral concept of guilt, *Schuld*, descends from the material concept of debt, *Schulden* (*On the Genealogy of Morality*, II.4–6, 1887). Mona's love is the pneumatic loan (Chapter 3) administered as a ledger: what she gave at birth she now itemizes, and her son's every breath is an installment in arrears. Deleuze and Guattari's family as a colony of capital is here a corporate subsidiary.

7.7 The attic

Mona forces Beau into the attic he dreaded as a child, a confinement he had believed was a dream and which she now tells him was a memory. In it are two figures: an emaciated man who resembles Beau, his imprisoned twin, and a gigantic phallic creature with insectile limbs, which Mona identifies as his father. When Jeeves breaks in and attacks it, the creature kills him.

The attic condenses the corpus's theory of paternity. It is Apollo's argument from the *Eumenides* made flesh: the father as pure insemination, a seed without a person (Chapter 1). It is Lacan's stone roller in the crocodile's jaws, imprisoned under the roof of the mother's house (Chapter 3). It fulfills the comic prophecy of *The Turtle's Head*, whose shrinking phallus returns as a monster. The imprisoned twin recalls Lovecraft's "The Dunwich Horror" (1929), in which a monstrous brother grows in the shuttered upper rooms of a farmhouse. And it inverts Gaston Bachelard's poetics of the house, in which the attic is the rational pole and

the cellar the irrational (*The Poetics of Space*, 1958). In Aster the attic is where the sovereign keeps what she has captured: in *Hereditary*, the headless matriarch; here, the headless father, all organ and no face.

7.8 Matricide

Enraged, Beau strangles his mother. He stops; she continues to choke and falls through a glass display case, apparently dead. It is the only act in the film that is unambiguously his, and it takes the precise form of the corpus's governing figure: the son, for once, administers breath. He takes it away from the woman who has held his since birth. Irigaray's founding matricide (Chapter 3) and Orestes' act are performed in a single gesture, and the glass case through which Mona falls is the diorama breaking. For an instant the enclosure is open.

7.9 The tribunal of water

Beau flees in a motorboat into a cave and emerges in a vast arena before an audience. A trial convenes on the water. Mona and her attorney, Dr. Cohen, prosecute; recorded evidence of every slight Beau ever offered his mother is displayed; his defender is pushed from a ledge to his death by one of Mona's employees. The motor explodes, the boat capsizes, and Beau drowns while the audience files out.

The sources converge. Kafka's "The Judgment" (1913) ends when a father sentences his son to death by drowning and the son, obedient, drops from a bridge into the river. Joyce's "Circe" (*Ulysses*, 1922) puts its Jewish everyman on hallucinatory trial for every shame of his life. The *Eumenides* is reversed: the matricide is condemned, the Furies prevail, and the amphitheater — the architecture in which the *Oresteia* was first performed — hosts the son's conviction. *Unetaneh Tokef* is completed: who by water. And the trial's evidence is the pre-scription in its archival form, a lifetime recorded in advance of its judgment.

The film's respiratory parenthesis closes. It opened on a newborn who would not breathe and closes on a man who cannot. The tunnel into the arena is the birth canal traversed in reverse, from world back to womb, and the womb is a court. The audience that leaves is the conspiracy dispersing: having breathed with the spectacle, it exhales and goes home.

7.10 Synthesis

Beau Is Afraid relocates the Breather from the demon and the commune into the mother, and from the mother into the institution she has become. It is the corpus's most explicit account of the pneumatic loan, and its sharpest refusal of consolation. Dani was breathed with; Beau is breathed for, audited, and finally drowned. The mother is not abject but sovereign, and her sovereignty takes the form Aster's later work will generalize: surveillance, recording, evidence, and an audience.

Chapter 8

Eddington: Influenza, Viral Sovereignty, and the Algorithmic Breather

Eddington (2025) completes the Breather's migration. Set in a fictional New Mexico town in late May 2020, during the first pandemic lockdown and the protests that followed the killing of George Floyd, it relocates pneumatocracy from the family into the polis and from the polis into the network (plot summary). Its figure is **influenza**: the astral *influence* from which the disease took its name, the *influencers* through whom the town's affects circulate, and the machine that finally inhales them all.

8.1 The respiratory polis

The film's politics are respiratory from the first scene. Sheriff Joe Cross, an asthmatic, refuses to wear a mask and insists he cannot breathe in one; he is stopped at the border of the neighboring Pueblo jurisdiction for entering it unmasked; he champions a citizen with similar respiratory complaints who is refused entry to a grocery store. The mayor, Ted Garcia, enforces the governor's mandate. Within days the town is convulsed by protests whose watchword, inherited from Eric Garner in 2014 and George Floyd in 2020, is the sentence *I can't breathe*.

Achille Mbembe wrote in April 2020 that the pandemic had revealed a universal right to breathe, and that modern power had long been distributed according to who is permitted to breathe freely and who is

made to suffocate (“The Universal Right to Breathe”). *Eddington* takes that diagnosis as its premise and refuses its moral clarity. Every faction claims breath. The protesters claim it against the police; the sheriff claims it against the mask; the mask claims it on behalf of the vulnerable. Roberto Esposito’s paired concepts organize the conflict. *Communitas* binds members through a shared *munus*, an obligation or gift that is also a debt; *immunitas* exempts the individual from that obligation and, in its modern form, protects life by injecting a controlled portion of what threatens it (*Communitas*, 1998; *Immunitas*, 2002). The mask is the immunitary device in its purest form, a membrane that interrupts conspiration. Joe’s refusal of it is a refusal of the debt, staged by a man who cannot in fact breathe well on his own: the asthmatic sovereign, claiming respiratory autonomy he does not possess.

8.2 Influenza, influence, influencers

The Italian *influenza* named epidemics attributed to the *influence* of the stars, a fluid thought to flow from the heavens into human bodies. *Eddington* is the corpus’s first film in which the Breather is astral in this sense: diffuse, invisible, and broadcast. Louise Cross, Joe’s wife, who makes disturbing dolls in the house — effigies that inherit Annie Graham’s miniatures — is drawn by her mother Dawn, a devotee of QAnon-like theories, toward Vernon Jefferson Peak, a charismatic preacher of child-trafficking and ritual-abuse conspiracies. A teenage boy, Brian, adopts the language of the protests to impress a girl who is herself a social-justice influencer. Joe’s rough handling of a protester circulates as a viral clip. Everyone in the town breathes the same feed.

The World Health Organization’s director-general called the phenomenon an *infodemic* in February 2020. The older theorists of mass irrationality had already described its mechanism. Theodor Adorno studied a newspaper astrology column as an instrument of dependence that trains readers to submit to opaque powers (*The Stars Down to Earth*, 1953), and in *Minima Moralia* called occultism the metaphysic of dunces (1951, §151). Richard Hofstadter’s “paranoid style” (1964) described a politics that sees history as a conspiracy directed by a demonic enemy. *Eddington* adds the respiratory literalism: a conspiracy theory is a breathing-together of the frightened, and in May 2020 every breath was a vector. Viral content and viral particles share a medium.

Louise's story is the film's most painful instance of the pneumatic loan. Her history with Ted Garcia, and the suggestion that she suffered abuse in youth, become property to be spent by others. Joe publicly accuses Garcia of having raped her as a teenager to win votes; Louise answers with a video denying his claim and leaves town with Vernon. Her trauma is conscripted twice, by a husband's campaign and by a cult's cosmology, and she ends, at a rally, pregnant with the preacher's child. She is a **Crowned Girl** in the corpus's terms (Chapter 9): a woman whose release from one enclosure is her coronation in another.

8.3 The Western and its degeneration

Aster developed a contemporary Western for years before *Hereditary* and later moved it into the pandemic. The genre brings its myth with it. Frederick Jackson Turner located American character at the frontier (1893); Richard Slotkin showed that the national mythology is a doctrine of *regeneration through violence* (1973; *Gunfighter Nation*, 1992). *High Noon* (1952) supplies the lone sheriff facing a town that will not stand with him; *The Man Who Shot Liberty Valance* (1962) supplies the law of the genre's afterlife: when the legend becomes fact, print the legend.

Eddington stages degeneration through mediation. Humiliated by Louise's denial and slapped by Garcia, Joe kills a mentally ill vagrant, Lodge, and contracts COVID-19 while disposing of the body. The murderer is infected by the victim's breath: conspiration operates even in the act that should sever it. Lodge is Agamben's *homo sacer* (1995), a life that may be taken with impunity, outside both law and sacrifice. Joe then kills Garcia and his son with a scoped rifle, stages the scene as an attack by antifa, and frames his Black deputy, Michael, for the crime. The framing recalls the ending of *Night of the Living Dead* (1968), in which a posse shoots the Black survivor, and it performs Girard's scapegoat mechanism at the speed of a news cycle.

Then the paranoid fantasy arrives in person. Armed men descend from a private jet with a cargo of left-wing protest signs and stage false-flag attacks across the town. The film grants the conspiracy theory diegetic reality while withholding its meaning: the attackers are real, their sponsors unknowable. The shootout ends when Brian appears, filming himself as he kills the last assailant and saves Joe. A year later he is a prominent conservative influencer. Liberty Valance's maxim is completed

for the platform age: the legend is not printed; it is posted, monetized, and fed back.

8.4 The frontier as cloud

Eddington borders the Pueblo of Santa Lupe, whose officer, Butterfly Jimenez, correctly suspects Joe and is killed in the crossfire. Patrick Wolfe's dictum that settler colonial invasion is a structure, not an event (2006), describes the town's geography. The frontier has not closed; it has been reterritorialized. The data center that Garcia championed and that the film's turmoil finally delivers is a water-hungry facility in the desert whose expansion, one critic notes, presses upon neighboring reservation land (A.V. Club). The new fort on the frontier does not hold soldiers. It holds servers, and it must be cooled: it drinks the region's water and conditions its air. It breathes for the town in the most literal sense available to infrastructure.

8.5 The glitch token as sigil

The data center belongs to a company called Solidgoldmagikarp. The name, as Aster has explained, refers not to a Pokémon but to an anomalous AI token that produces erratic behavior (TIME). In February 2023 Jessica Rumbelow and Matthew Watkins reported that certain strings in a widely used language-model vocabulary, *SolidGoldMagikarp* among them, provoked bizarre outputs, evasions, and hallucinations. The strings had been assigned slots in the model's vocabulary but appeared too rarely in training to acquire meaning. A glitch token is a signifier with a place and no sense, around which a machine's behavior turns uncanny.

It is Paimon's sigil for the computational age. In *Hereditary* a mark on a pole indexed a sovereign the characters could not see. In *Midsommar* an oracle's meaningless marks were converted into scripture (Chapter 6). In *Eddington* the sovereign's name is itself a meaningless mark from inside a machine that converts the noise of a whole society into probable text. Aster has said that the film is really about a data center being built (IndieWire), that the data center is the only unequivocal winner, and that the movie itself is training data. On this account the town's grievances, slogans, sermons, and videos are inputs. The data center is the final Hårga: it breathes in everyone's breath and breathes out the town's future.

8.6 The astronomer's monkeys

A constellational resonance, offered under the caveat of the Prefatory Note. Sir Arthur Eddington, the astronomer whose 1919 eclipse observations confirmed general relativity, coined the phrase "arrow of time" in *The Nature of the Physical World* (1928), and in the same book popularized Émile Borel's image of an army of monkeys at typewriters who, by chance, might reproduce every book in the British Museum. A town named Eddington becomes the site of a machine that industrializes the monkeys: it produces plausible text not by chance but by statistics, from the typing of millions. And the arrow of time, Eddington's name for entropy's one-way direction, describes the film's final shot exactly. History runs from the town, centered in the frame at the opening, to the data center that dwarfs it at the close.

8.7 The Hollow King and the mother who speaks

Joe survives the shootout quadriplegic and brain-damaged and is elected mayor. He cannot move or speak. His mother-in-law, Dawn, speaks on his behalf, and under her watch the data center opens. Returning from the ribbon-cutting, they watch news footage of Vernon and a pregnant Louise at a rally. Dawn and a caregiver lift Joe into bed, and both lie down beside him.

The ending assembles the corpus's figures in a single room. Joe is Christian, paralyzed and mute, and Peter, a vessel crowned so that others may rule through him: the corpus's last **Hollow King**. Dawn is the maternal Breather returned, a conspiracist mother who now literally supplies the sovereign's voice. Louise is the Crowned Girl, absorbed and pregnant. And outside the window stands the Breather that has replaced all of them, humming in the desert. The synchronous apotheosis of *Eddington* occurs at the scale of a nation: a whole public's breath has been taken up into a single machine, and no one in the town can say whose voice is speaking.

8.8 Plague theater

Antonin Artaud's lecture "The Theater and the Plague" (1933; collected in *The Theater and Its Double*, 1938) argued that the plague dissolves social forms and releases the cruelty latent in a population, and that theater should act on its audience as the plague does. *Eddington* is plague theater in Artaud's sense, but its stage is the feed. Every citizen performs for an audience they cannot see, and every performance becomes data. Albert Camus's *The Plague* (1947) answered its epidemic with the solidarity of a doctor and his volunteers. *Eddington* has no doctor. Its plague is answered by influencers, and the only institution that benefits is the one that inhales the performances.

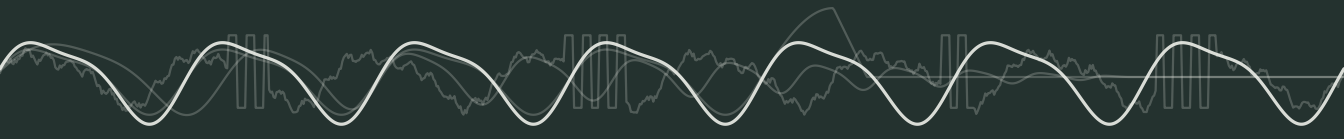
Part III

Comparison and Synthesis

9 Comparative Pneumatologies: Aster among the Horror and Mythological Traditions

10 Formal Pneumatics: Diorama, Duration, Sound, and Apneic Spectatorship

11 The Conspiration Thesis: Toward a Pneumatology of Heteronomy



Chapter 9

Comparative Pneumatologies: Aster among the Horror and Mythological Traditions

Aster's films converse with a canon, and the conversation is precise. This chapter reads the corpus against five comparative fields — the satanic-succession film, folk horror, the cinema of terrible mothers, the literary Gothic of heredity, and mythological fiction — and derives from the comparison two new genre figures.

9.1 The satanic-succession cycle

Rosemary's Baby (Levin 1967; Polanski 1968) is *Hereditary*'s nearest ancestor. A coven of kindly neighbors drugs a woman with a chocolate dessert, impregnates her inside a ring of naked congregants, and secures her consent to mother Satan's son; the assembled acclaim "Hail Satan." *Hereditary* answers with "Hail Paimon," but redistributes the roles. The mother refuses; the vessel is the son; the women of the line are the coven's founders rather than its instruments. *Midsommar* inverts the canonical rape scene by sex, as Chapter 6 showed. *The Omen* (1976) supplies the logic of succession: a conspiracy engineers a male heir, and a nanny hangs herself in public as an offering to him.

The Exorcist (Blatty 1971; Friedkin 1973) is pneumatological at its root. Its demon, Pazuzu, is the Assyro-Babylonian king of the wind-demons, bearer of the southwest wind; possession manifests as voice, breath, and

expectoration. In the climax Father Karras demands that the demon leave the girl and enter him, and then hurls himself through the window. Peter Graham's leap from the attic window, followed by the demon's entry into his body, restages the transfer with its sequence reversed: the leap precedes the possession and enables it. *Don't Look Now* (du Maurier 1971; Roeg 1973) contributes grief over a drowned child, clairvoyant sisters, and a father who misrecognizes a vision of his own funeral. Precognition is pre-scription seen too early to be read.

9.2 Folk horror and its heirs

The Wicker Man (Hardy and Shaffer, 1973), with *Witchfinder General* (1968) and *The Blood on Satan's Claw* (1971), forms what Mark Gatiss called British folk horror's unholy trinity. Sergeant Howie, a virgin, a devout Christian, and the representative of the law, comes of his own will to Summerisle and is burned in a wicker colossus to restore the failed harvest; Lord Summerisle's grandfather had revived the old gods as a means of agricultural management. *Midsommar* departs from its model in three ways. Its Christian is Christian in name only: secularization is complete, and only the name remains to be burned. Its rite is cyclical rather than instrumental: the Hårga need no crop failure to justify it. And its point of view belongs not to the victim but to the elect: the film moves from Howie's horror to Dani's smile.

Shirley Jackson's "The Lottery" (1948) sets an annual killing on a June morning in an ordinary village, ratified by a proverb about the harvest; its horror is the banality of a ritual no one remembers how to justify. Thomas Tryon's *Harvest Home* (1973) imagines a New England matriarchal agrarian cult whose male intruder is finally mutilated and silenced. Robert Eggers's *The Witch* (2015) ends exactly where *Midsommar* does: a girl whose family has been destroyed accepts the offer of a collective and rises, naked and laughing, into the coven's ecstasy. Jordan Peele's *Get Out* (2017) supplies the Sunken Place, a paralysis in which the victim watches his body from within, voiceless — Christian's condition in the temple — and a family conspiracy that transplants a stranger's will into a host body, which is Paimon's procedure without the demon.

9.3 The terrible mothers

Thomas De Quincey's "Levana and Our Ladies of Sorrow" (1845) names three mothers: Our Lady of Tears, Our Lady of Sighs, and Our Lady of Darkness. Dario Argento built his Three Mothers trilogy on them (*Suspiria*, 1977; *Inferno*, 1980; *Mother of Tears*, 2007), and Luca Guadagnino's *Suspiria* (2018) reconceived the first as a coven of dance teachers in divided Berlin who discover that their pupil is Mother Suspiriorum herself. *Suspiria* means *sighs*, breaths of sorrow. The Mother of Sighs is the pneumatic mother in her mythic form, and Guadagnino's dance-ritual and Aster's maypole belong to the same liturgy.

Darren Aronofsky's *mother!* (2017) makes the house the mother's body and fills it with a crowd that invades and finally devours her child, an image Beau's apartment siege recalls. Jennifer Kent's *The Babadook* (2014) studies a widow whose husband died driving her to give birth, so that the son's arrival and the father's death coincide, as they do in Beau's story; its heroine's ambivalence toward her son anticipates Annie's confession. Lars von Trier's *Antichrist* (2009) opens with a child falling from a window while his parents make love, binding sex, a window, and a child's death into one image. Roman Polanski's *The Tenant* (1976) delivers its persecuted lodger, after the apartment's previous occupant has leapt from its window, to the same window. In Aster the window recurs as the threshold of respiration and death: Charlie dies leaning from one for air; Peter leaps from one into possession.

9.4 The Gothic of heredity

Nathaniel Hawthorne's preface to *The House of the Seven Gables* (1851) states the visitation clause in secular prose: the wrong-doing of one generation lives into the successive ones. The curse pronounced by the dispossessed Matthew Maule, that God would give his persecutor blood to drink, descends on the Pyncheons as death with blood in the throat: heredity as strangulation, two centuries before Charlie's anaphylaxis. Poe's "The Fall of the House of Usher" (1839) fuses family and building into one organism, gives its last heir a morbid acuteness of the senses that anticipates Beau's, and entombs a twin alive.

H. P. Lovecraft made heredity the engine of cosmic horror. In "Facts Concerning the Late Arthur Jermyn and His Family" (1920) and "The Rats in

the Walls" (1924) a family line conceals a degenerate origin; in "The Dunwich Horror" (1929) a monstrous twin grows in the shuttered upper rooms of a farmhouse; in "The Shadow over Innsmouth" (1936) the narrator discovers his descent from the sea-dwelling Deep Ones and, after his terror, resolves with exultation to join them. The Innsmouth ending is Dani's smile in prose. The comparison also clarifies a difference: Lovecraft's heredity is animated by a racial dread of mixture, while Aster's is familial, psychic, and, by *Eddington*, technological. The fear of inheritance has been detached from blood and reattached to breath.

Franz Kafka's "The Judgment" (1913), in which a father sentences his son to death by drowning and the son obeys, and *The Trial* (1925) govern *Beau Is Afraid*; Joyce's "Circe" episode (*Ulysses*, 1922) and Philip Roth's *Portnoy's Complaint* (1969) supply its comic Jewish confession; Woody Allen's "Oedipus Wrecks" (1989), in which a vanished mother reappears as an enormous face over Manhattan commenting on her son's life, is its broadest precedent. Mona Wassermann is that face, given a corporation.

9.5 Mythological fiction

Homer's *Odyssey* structures *Beau Is Afraid* as an anti-*nostos*. The Phaeacian bard who sings Odysseus his own story (Book VIII) becomes the forest troupe; the pregnant Penelope waits for no one; and the descent to the dead (Book XI), where Odysseus learns that his mother died of longing for him and three times fails to embrace her shade, becomes a homecoming in which the dead mother is alive and the embrace is a strangulation. J. R. R. Tolkien's *The Lord of the Rings* (1954–55), invoked in Aster's own description, reverses direction: Frodo leaves home for Mordor; Beau leaves a Mordor for home, which is Mordor. The surveillant Eye is maternal.

L. Frank Baum's Oz (1900), and Victor Fleming's film of it (1939), end with a girl who insists there is no place like home. Aster's own formula for *Midsommar* — a *Wizard of Oz* for perverts — names the inversion: Dani stays in Oz. In Oz the witch dies by water; in the corpus water drowns the son, and fire takes the men. Ovid's Philomela (*Metamorphoses* VI), whose tongue is cut out and who weaves her testimony into a tapestry, stands behind both Christian's muteness and *Midsommar*'s painted panels, which narrate the violence before any character can speak of it. The *Bacchae* and the *Oresteia* (Chapter 1) complete the field.

9.6 Two new figures: the Crowned Girl and the Hollow King

Carol Clover's **Final Girl** (*Men, Women, and Chain Saws*, 1992) survives the slasher by separation. Watchful, resourceful, sexually reticent, she isolates the threat, outlasts her friends, and kills or escapes the monster. Aster's corpus, read with *The Witch* and Guadagnino's *Suspiria*, produces her successor. The **Crowned Girl** triumphs not by separation but by fusion. She is elected and crowned by the collective that destroyed her family, and her survival is her incorporation: Dani, the May Queen; Thomasin, rising into the coven; Susie Bannion, revealed as a Mother; Charlie Graham, crowned posthumously as the archive of a male king; Louise Cross, pregnant at the preacher's rally. The Final Girl's victory is to breathe alone at dawn. The Crowned Girl's victory is to breathe with everyone.

Her structural counterpart is the **Hollow King**: a male elected as a vessel, crowned or enthroned so that a collective may rule through him. Peter Graham, emptied for Paimon; Christian, the year-king, paralyzed inside a bear; Beau, the son tried as a defendant in his mother's arena; Joe Cross, a mute mayor whose mother-in-law speaks his words. The Hollow King's sovereignty is vacancy. His crown is placed upon a breathless body.

Robin Wood's foundational formula for the American horror film was the return of the repressed: what a society represses returns as the monster (1979). Aster's corpus requires a revision. What returns in these films is not what was pushed down into the unconscious but what was breathed in from the shared air: the coven's covenant, the commune's grief, the mother's audit, the feed's paranoia. The dissertation calls this the **return of the respired**. Its monster does not rise from beneath. It is already in the lungs.

Chapter 10

Formal Pneumatics: Diorama, Duration, Sound, and Apneic Spectatorship

10

Aster's style is not the ornament of his argument but its final instrument. The films do not merely depict collectives that breathe for their subjects; they govern the respiration of their audiences, holding it, releasing it, and synchronizing it across an auditorium. This chapter names the resulting regime **apneic spectatorship**.

10.1 The diorama and the providential camera

Aster's master form is the enclosure observed from outside. In *Hereditary* it is literal: Annie's miniatures, the camera's passage into one of them, and an exterior shot in which the Graham house passes from day to night in an instant, as if someone had flipped the switch of a dollhouse lamp. In *Midsommar* it is pictorial: painted panels that narrate the plot before the first scene, and symmetrical compositions that arrange the commune like figures in a frieze. In *Beau Is Afraid* it is architectural and textual: a mother's glass house, and a city in which every surface carries a warning, a sign, or a notice. In *Eddington* it is mediated: frames within frames — phones, livestreams, campaign videos, broadcasts — and a film that opens on the site of a proposed data center and closes on the finished building, now dwarfing the town that once filled the frame.

The overhead shot, the slow push-in, and the tableau share an implied position: the vantage of whoever built the enclosure. Leibniz's *Theodicy* (1710) imagined God as the architect who chose the best of all possible worlds and beheld it whole. Aster's camera is a theodicy without benevolence, the architect's view of a world designed for the subject's capture. The widely reported exactitude of Aster's advance planning is the formal homologue of predestination. The auteur's control and the coven's design are one design seen from two sides, and the spectator, granted the architect's vantage, is enrolled in the conspiracy as its witness.

The diorama also grows. House, village, terrarium, nation: by *Eddington* the enclosure has expanded until it contains the media environment through which the audience itself receives the film.

10.2 Duration: the long take as apnea

Aster's protracted takes do more than build tension; they regulate breathing. After Charlie's death the camera holds on Peter's face in the car, then follows his silent drive home and his night in bed, withholding the discovery until morning, when Annie's scream arrives from offscreen. The spectator holds breath for the length of a night, and the scream is a collective exhalation. At the Ättestupa the camera declines to look away from the second fall or from the mallet, and the commune's groans set the rhythm of the scene and, by mimicry, of the audience. *Beau Is Afraid* opens with an apneic interval: the spectator waits, with the mother, for a newborn's cry. *Eddington* holds its first half in a long inhalation of grievance and releases it in the convulsive exhalation of its final shootout.

Hitchcock's account of suspense — the bomb beneath the table that the audience knows about and the characters do not (Truffaut, *Hitchcock*, 1966) — describes the pre-scription as a spectatorial technique. In every Aster feature the audience reads the decree before the characters do: the sigil on the pole, the painted panels, the recorded archive, the data center in the opening frames. Suspense is the affect of knowing the decree and being unable to warn. Its bodily form is the held breath.

10.3 Sound as breath

Charlie's click, a non-pulmonic consonant (Chapter 5), is the corpus's signature sound because it is a voice without breath. Its counterpart is the score of *Hereditary*, composed by Colin Stetson, a saxophonist whose signature technique is circular breathing: inhaling through the nose while pushing air stored in the cheeks through the instrument, so that the tone never breaks for a breath. Whatever the methods of individual cues, the choice of composer is exact. Circular breathing abolishes the breath-pause. It is the sound of a lineage without interruption, a breath passed on without ever being drawn by the one who sounds it — Paimon's mode of transmission rendered as music.

Bobby Krlic, who scored *Midsommar* and *Beau Is Afraid* and co-scored *Eddington* with Daniel Pemberton, works in a register in which score and diegetic breath merge. *Midsommar*'s sound design binds the commune's groans, wails, pants, and screams into the musical fabric until the boundary between the film's music and its characters' respiration dissolves. The mating rite is scored by the women's breathing; the temple, by the volunteers' screams and the commune's echo. The soundtrack is itself a lamenting pack.

10.4 Body genres and the lamenting audience

Linda Williams identified pornography, horror, and melodrama as "body genres" whose spectators' bodies are caught in involuntary mimicry of the bodies on screen — the orgasm, the scream, the sob ("Film Bodies," 1991). Aster fuses all three. *Midsommar* is a horror film, a breakup melodrama, and, in its mating rite, a scene of sexual display; *Beau Is Afraid* is farce, melodrama, and a fable of sex as death; *Hereditary* is a family melodrama possessed by horror. The spectator is drawn into each mimicry in turn and becomes, in the auditorium, a member of Canetti's lamenting pack: gasping, flinching, and wailing in company.

Peter Sloterdijk's *Spheres* trilogy (1998–2004) describes human existence as the cohabitation of shared interiors, atmospheres made by and for those who breathe them. The cinema auditorium is such a sphere: a conditioned interior in which strangers breathe the same air in the dark at a rhythm set by a film. It is the last conspiracy in the literal sense, and

Aster designs for it. His films do not only show collectives breathing together; they assemble one.

10.5 Laughter as emergency exhalation

Audiences laugh at Aster's films, often uneasily, and Aster has insisted on their comedy; a 2023 *New York Times* profile announced that he had something funny to show us. Henri Bergson's *Laughter* (1900) located the comic in the mechanical encrusted upon the living: we laugh when a person behaves like a mechanism. Kleist's marionette (Chapter 6) is the limit case. Aster's horror inverts Bergson's formula. Its premise is that the living is a thin crust upon the mechanical — upon covenant, ritual, audit, and algorithm — and its comedy flares wherever the crust wears through.

Physiologically, laughter is a series of forced exhalations. In an apneic cinema it is the spectator's emergency vent, the body reclaiming its breath from a film that has been holding it. Benjamin assigned character, and therefore freedom, to comedy (Chapter 1). The uneasy laughter at the mating rite or in Mona's attic is character's last flicker inside fate: the audience exhaling on its own account, briefly, before the film breathes for it again.

10.6 Apneic spectatorship

Apneic spectatorship names the formal regime in which a film governs its audience's respiration — holding it through duration and suspense, releasing it through scream and laughter, and synchronizing it through bodily mimicry — so that the auditorium breathes as one. Aster's films are not only about conspiration. They perform it upon the people watching, and each ends by placing its spectator where its protagonist stands: breathed with, like the Crowned Girl, or breathed for, like the Hollow King.

Chapter 11

The Conspiration Thesis: Toward a Pneumatology of Heteronomy

11

The readings assemble into a single theory. This chapter states it as ten propositions, sets the four features side by side, situates the theory within the philosophy of horror, and turns its method back upon itself.

11.1 Ten propositions

I. The pneumatic loan. No first breath is one's own. The subject begins as a respiration conducted on its behalf by a maternal body, and its first independent breath is a separation that is also a debt (Irigaray; Rank). Aster's films are notices of collection: Peter inherits a breath that was never his; Beau's every breath is an installment in arrears.

II. Community is conspiration. Every collective in the corpus is bound by breath before it is bound by belief: the séance circle with its held breath, the lamenting pack with its mirrored groans, the arena audience that exhales and leaves, the feed through which a town inhales one panic. Esposito's *munus*, the obligation that constitutes a *communitas*, is in Aster a shared debt of air.

III. Sovereignty is pneumatocracy. To rule, in this corpus, is to administer breath: to give it (the Hårga's holding), to take it (the coven's decapitations, the mother's tribunal of water), to synchronize it (acclamation, Agamben's glory), and to suspend it (Christian's paralysis, Joe's muteness). Carl Schmitt defined the sovereign as the one who decides on the exception

(*Political Theology*, 1922); Aster's sovereign decides on the breath. Where Mbembe's necropolitics names the power to expose to death (2003), pneumatocracy names the power to decide who breathes, and with whom.

IV. Inheritance is respiratory debt. Heredity is the transmission of a breath not one's own: the Roman custom of catching the last breath, inverted; the phantom of Abraham and Torok; Laplanche's intromission. Nietzsche observed that a community's debt to its ancestors grows with its power until the ancestor is transfigured into a god (*On the Genealogy of Morality*, II.19). The corpus stages that apotheosis three times: Ellen as queen of a demon's court, the Hårga's ancestral tree, Mona's conglomerate.

V. The pre-scription and the oracle machine. The Breather writes before it breathes. Fate appears first as a text — an obituary card, painted panels, a notice under the door, a recorded archive, a feed — and only afterward as an event. Its hermeneutic engine is the oracle machine, which converts noise into necessity: Ruben's marks into scripture, a glitch token into a sovereign's name.

VI. The Breather migrates. Demon, commune, mother-corporation, algorithm: each feature reassigns the functions of the demonic sovereign to a modern institution without loss of power. Schmitt argued that the significant concepts of the modern theory of the state are secularized theological concepts; Aster extends the claim to the family, the community, the firm, and the network. Weber's disenchantment of the world (1917) is answered not by re-enchantment but by re-possession. Mark Fisher located the eerie in questions of agency — an agent where none should be, or none where one should be — and called capital an eerie entity (*The Weird and the Eerie*, 2016). The data center of *Eddington* is the eerie in Fisher's precise sense: the Breather has become an agency without a face.

VII. The diorama expands. Each migration enlarges the enclosure: house, village, terrarium, network-as-nation. By *Eddington* the diorama contains the media environment in which its audience lives, and there is no longer an outside from which to observe it.

VIII. Endings are synchronous apotheoses. The films' consolations are moments when individual respiration coincides with the collective's: a

coronation acclaimed in one breath, a smile inside a mirrored wail, a son drowning while an audience exhales and departs, a mute mayor at a ribbon-cutting. The happy ending, in this corpus, is the end of one's own breath.

IX. The Crowned Girl and the Hollow King. The corpus distributes gender by breath. Women are incorporated through shared respiration and crowned by the collective that destroyed their families; men are emptied into vessels and enthroned so that others may rule through them.

X. The return of the respired, and the last conspiracy. What returns in Aster's horror is not the repressed but the inhaled. Because the films govern the breathing of their audiences, the cinema itself becomes the corpus's final conspiracy: a room of strangers breathing together at a rhythm they did not set.

11.2 The four pneumatocracies

Read down its columns, the table records the thesis's historical argument: the Breather grows more abstract as the diorama grows larger, and the apparatus of pre-scription migrates from the grimoire to the server.

	Hereditary (2018)	*Midsommar* (2019)	*Beau Is Afraid* (2023)	*Eddington* (2025)
Breather	Demonic: Paimon, through a matriarchal coven	Ethnic-communal: the Hårga	Maternal-corporate: Mona Wassermann	Viral-algorithmic: the feed and the data center
Diorama	House	Village	Glass terrarium; psyche as world	Network as nation
Primal respiratory event	Anaphylaxis; decapitation at a car window	Carbon-monoxide murder-suicide; mirrored wailing	A newborn who does not cry; a son who drowns	Asthma, masks, "I can't breathe"
Apparatus of pre-scription	Obituary card, sigils, grimoires, wall inscriptions, miniatures	Painted panels, runes, the *Rubi Radr*	Prescriptions, notes, recordings, the trial's archive	Posts, videos, campaign ads, training data
Synchronous apotheosis	Acclamation in the treehouse	Dani's smile as the temple burns	Drowning before a departing audience	A mute mayor at the data center's opening
Crowned figure	Charlie, crowned posthumously	Dani, the May Queen	Mona, the sovereign mother	Louise, pregnant at the rally
Hollow King	Peter Graham	Christian	Beau Wassermann	Joe Cross

11.3 Horror after the buffered self

Noël Carroll defined art-horror by its monsters, beings categorically interstitial and impure (*The Philosophy of Horror*, 1990). Aster's corpus contains few such creatures, and its most memorable — the attic's phallic father — is a joke about the paternal function. The monstrous in Aster is a relation rather than a being: a breath held in common. Eugene Thacker distinguished the world-for-us, the world-in-itself, and the world-without-us, and located cosmic horror in the last (*In the Dust of This Planet*, 2011). Aster's horror requires a fourth term, the **world-through-us**: the world that breathes through the subject and uses the subject's breath to sustain itself. Its terror is not that the world is indifferent to us but that it is intimately interested in us, as a lung is interested in air.

Thomas Ligotti's *The Conspiracy against the Human Race* (2010) uses the word in a pessimist's sense: the species' tacit agreement not to see the horror of consciousness. Aster's conspiracies invert it. They do not deny horror; they offer a consolation so total that it becomes indistinguishable from horror. What unites the two is the puppet — Ligotti's marionettes, Kleist's dancers, Aster's vessels — the figure in whom grace and capture coincide.

11.4 The paranoid reader

Aster's films train their audiences in paranoid reading. Sigils in the backgrounds, runes in the mise-en-scène, logos on the products, and archives withheld until the end reward the viewer who scans each frame for design, and a culture of online decoding has grown up around the films. The audience becomes a hermeneutic congregation, a conspiracy of readers breathing over the same frames.

Paul Ricoeur grouped Marx, Nietzsche, and Freud as a school of suspicion that reads every surface as the disguise of a hidden force (*Freud and Philosophy*, 1965). Eve Kosofsky Sedgwick characterized paranoid reading as anticipatory, mimetic, and devoted to exposure, and proposed reparative reading as its alternative (1997; 2003). Bruno Latour noted with alarm that the methods of critique had come to resemble those of conspiracy theory ("Why Has Critique Run out of Steam?", 2004). *Eddington* turns these observations into a plot. It depicts a town of

paranoid readers, grants their conspiracy theories diegetic reality, withholds their meaning, and shows that the only beneficiary of all the decoding is the machine that harvests it. Aster's latest film diagnoses the reading habits his earlier films cultivated.

This dissertation is not exempt. A reading organized around conspiracy is itself conspiratorial: it breathes together with its object. Its defense is the turn the Conclusion makes. To name a conspiracy is to stand, for an instant, outside its rhythm, and a reading that searches for the interruptions of a design, rather than only for the design, has begun to be reparative.

Conclusion

Expiration: Toward an Ethics of the Caesura

Across ten films Aster has built a negative pneumatology: a sustained account of the ways in which a subject's breath is borrowed, administered, and finally reclaimed by a collective — demon, commune, mother, machine. Every feature ends with breath surrendered, and every surrender is staged as consolation. A negative theology, however, outlines the shape of what it denies. This conclusion draws that shape.

The counterfeit of substitution

Emmanuel Levinas described the psyche as the other in the same: a self constituted by its exposure to another person, by a responsibility that precedes choice and that he figured in the vocabulary of respiration and inspiration (*Otherwise than Being*, 1974). For Levinas this exposure never fuses self and other; responsibility depends on the distance it crosses. Aster's collectives counterfeit it. The Hårga's mirrored wailing simulates the gesture of substitution — *I feel what you feel* — while annulling the distance that would make responsibility possible. Conspiration abolishes the other. Inspiration, in Levinas's sense, requires that the other remain other. The difference between the two is the whole of the ethical question these films pose.

The caesura

In his "Remarks on Oedipus" (1804), Hölderlin argued that tragic representation requires a caesura: a counter-rhythmic interruption in the onrushing sequence of representations, at which not the change of representations but representation itself appears. The caesura is a breath-pause made structural. Pneumatocracy's sound, as Chapter 10 heard it, is circular breathing: an unbroken tone with no pause in which anyone might draw a breath of their own. If the corpus's negative image is the breath without interval, its ethics is the interval itself — the moment between breaths when neither self nor collective is breathing, and when, therefore, something can be decided.

The films contain such caesurae, and each is closed. Annie refuses maternity and is beheaded. Peter leaps from the window and is possessed. Josh photographs the scripture and is killed. Beau strangles his mother and is drowned. Butterfly Jimenez suspects the truth and is shot. Yet each interruption shows where the interval lies, and the rigor with which the films close them is a measure of how much they matter. Aster's cinema is an inventory of interrupted interruptions.

Toward a respiratory ethics

Three principles follow from the corpus by inversion. First, breath is one's own without being property: Irigaray's cultivation of breath (*Between East and West*, 2002) and Mbembe's universal right to breathe (2020) describe a respiration that belongs to the one who draws it and to no one else. Second, sharing is rhythm, not synchrony: a community may breathe in one another's presence without breathing in unison, and Esposito's *communitas*, read affirmatively, is the sharing of a lack rather than a substance. Third, the interval is the place of the other: it is in the pause that another may speak, and a collective that abolishes the pause has abolished the other's voice — the precise condition of Christian in the temple and of Joe Cross in his bed.

The scapegoat

At the time of writing, Aster's next feature has been announced under the title *Scapegoat*, its plot undisclosed (Prefatory Note). Nothing should be predicted of it. The title nonetheless names the figure this dissertation has found at the center of the oeuvre. William Tyndale coined the English word in 1530 for the goat of Leviticus 16, sent into the wilderness bearing the community's sins on the Day of Atonement — the day on which, in the liturgy of *Unetaneh Tokef*, the year's decree is sealed. In Athens, at the early-summer festival of the Thargelia, a *pharmakos* was driven out to purify the city. Jacques Derrida showed how, in Plato, *pharmakon* — drug, remedy, poison, writing — is shadowed by *pharmakos* ("Plato's Pharmacy," 1968). Breath, drug, script, and sacrifice, the four elements of Aster's pneumatocracy, converge in a single word.

Last breath

Aster's films ask who breathes for us, and they answer without consolation: our families, our communities, our institutions, our machines, and, for two or three hours in a dark room, the films themselves. Their rigor makes visible what they deny. To breathe in the presence of another without being breathed by them is the whole of the freedom these films withhold — and, because they withhold it so exactly, the whole of the freedom they make thinkable.

Glossary of Coined Terms

Apneic spectatorship. The formal regime by which a film governs its audience's breathing: holding it through duration and suspense, releasing it through scream and laughter, synchronizing it through bodily mimicry (Chapter 10).

The Breather. The sovereign entity that breathes for the subject — demon, commune, mother-corporation, or algorithm (Chapters 5–8, 11).

Caesural ethics. An ethics of the interval between breaths, in which neither self nor collective breathes and a decision becomes possible; derived from Hölderlin's caesura and Levinas's inspiration (Conclusion).

Circular sovereignty. Pneumatocracy's acoustic emblem: a breath without pause, after the circular-breathing technique of *Hereditary*'s composer (Chapter 10).

Conspiration. Breathing-together, recovered from Latin *conspirare*; the respiratory bond of a collective, prior to its beliefs (Introduction; Chapter 6).

Crowned Girl. Successor to Clover's Final Girl: a young woman who triumphs by fusion with the collective that destroyed her family (Chapter 9).

Expanding diorama. Aster's master form, the enclosure observed from outside, which grows from house to village to terrarium to network across the features (Chapters 5, 10, 11).

Hollow King. A male elected or crowned as a vessel, so that a collective may rule through him (Chapters 5, 9).

Levana function. The paternal act of raising the newborn out of the maternal element, after De Quincey's Levana; vacant in *Beau Is Afraid* (Chapter 7).

Oracle machine. After Turing, any apparatus that converts noise into necessity, from the Hårga's oracle to the glitch token (Chapters 6, 8).

Pneumatic loan. The structure in which the subject's breath begins as a debt to the body that breathed for it (Chapter 3).

Pneumatocracy. Sovereignty exercised through the administration of breath: its granting, withdrawal, synchronization, and suspension (Introduction; Chapter 11).

Pre-scription. Fate written before it is lived; the Breather's text, from obituary card to training data (Chapter 1).

Respiratory parenthesis. The bracketing of a life between a first breath that does not come and a last breath taken under water (Chapter 7).

Return of the respired. A revision of Robin Wood's return of the repressed: what returns is not what was pushed down but what was breathed in (Chapter 9).

Synchronous apotheosis. The ending in which individual respiration coincides with the collective's (Introduction; Chapters 6, 11).

World-through-us. A fourth term beside Thacker's world-for-us, world-in-itself, and world-without-us: the world that breathes through the subject (Chapter 11).

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Ari Aster; Hereditary; Midsommar; Beau Is Afraid; Eddington; Scapegoat; *pneumatology*; *conspiration*; *pneumatocracy*; *heteronomy*; *autonomy*; *inherited guilt*; *visitation clause*; *Exodus* 20:5; *Ezekiel* 18; *fate*; *guilt-context*; *Walter Benjamin*; Trauerspiel; *Greek tragedy*; Oresteia; Bacchae; Trachiniae; Unetaneh Tokef; *pre-scription*; *transgenerational haunting*; *phantom*; *crypt*; *intromission*; *birth trauma*; *anxiety*; angustiae; *Otto Rank*; *Luce Irigaray*; *forgetting of air*; *matricide*; *Oedipus*; *Lacan*; *Name-of-the-Father*; *Schreber*; *monstrous-feminine*; *abjection*; Ars Goetia; *Paimon*; *grimoire*; *séance*; *Spiritualism*; *folk horror*; The Wicker Man; *Frazer*; The Golden Bough; *external soul*; *year-king*; *Adam of Bremen*; *Norse religion*; *blood eagle*; *sacrifice*; *scapegoat*; pharmakon; pharmakos; *René Girard*; *Elias Canetti*; *lamenting pack*; *collective effervescence*; *Pentecost*; *xenoglossia*; *Kleist*; *marionette*; *Bergson*; *laughter*; *Roberto Esposito*; communitas; immunitas; *Achille Mbembe*; *right to breathe*; *Peter Sloterdijk*; *atmoterrorism*; COVID-19; *infodemic*; *influenza*; *conspiracy theory*; *paranoid style*; *paranoid reading*; *reparative reading*; *Western*; *frontier myth*; *settler colonialism*; *data centers*; *glitch tokens*; *SolidGoldMagikarp*; *oracle machine*; *algorithmic sovereignty*; *eerie*; *world-through-us*; *diorama*; *long take*; *apneic spectatorship*; *body genres*; *circular breathing*; *post-horror*; *elevated horror*; A24; *Final Girl*; *Crowned Girl*; *Hollow King*; *return of the respired*; *Levinas*; *inspiration*; *Hölderlin*; *caesura*; *respiratory ethics.*

To breathe in the presence of another without being breathed by them is the whole of the freedom these films withhold — and, because they withhold it so exactly, the whole of the freedom they make thinkable.



Set in Lora.